BENGALURU - SATURDAY - MAY 2, 2026

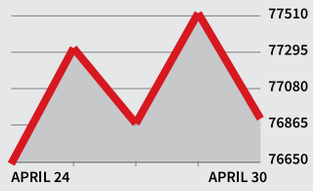
₹10 • Pages 10 • Volume 4 • Number 121

www.businessline.in

businessline thehindubusinessline

the hindu businessline.

SENSEX 76913.50 (-750.50)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23997.55	-175.50
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.94	-0.37
US Dollar (in ₹)	94.91	+0.81
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	149661.00	-793
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	240331.00	-265

MONSOON WATCH. **El Nino may last** until January 2027, could impact kharif and rabi crops, says India Meteorological Department **p8**

AUTO FOCUS. **BMW F 450 GS** improves performance and features but lacks distinctive GS character **p4**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

RNI No. KARENG/2023/85271

QUICKLY.

FISCAL COMMITMENT

'Govt to maintain capex despite global challenges'

New Delhi: The prolonged West Asia crisis has led to fiscal stress and uncertainty, but the government remains committed to the budgeted ₹12.22 lakh crore capital expenditure in the current fiscal, Expenditure Secretary V Vualnam has said. The upcoming few months, the next quarter and the year ahead will be very difficult to envisage with lots of possible stress points, he stressed. **p3**

WAR IMPACT

Centre allows *force majeure* **relief for govt contracts**

New Delhi: The Centre has allowed extension of timelines by two to four months without penalties in cases where supply chain disruptions have affected execution of government contracts due to the West Asia war. According to an office memorandum issued by the Department of Expenditure, procuring entities may invoke *force majeure* for contracts impacted by disruptions linked to the prevailing West Asia situation. **p10**

Steep hike in commercial LPG prices; other fuels not touched

BALANCING ACT. Petrol, diesel, domestic LPG prices unchanged to protect mass consumers

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The government on Friday tried to balance its energy import arithmetic by steeply raising prices of commodities used by industries such as commercial LPG and bulk diesel, while keeping retail prices of petrol, diesel and household LPG unchanged.

Rates of jet fuel used in domestic scheduled flights have not been raised.

RATE SHOCK. Effective May 1, the price of commercial LPG was raised by ₹993 per 19-kg cylinder or roughly 47.8% on-month

RECORD HIKE

Effective May 1, the price of LPG for commercial users was raised by ₹993 per 19-kg cylinder or roughly 47.8 per cent month-on-month, which is a record. Similarly, the rate for 5-kg FTL cylinders was hiked by ₹261.50 per unit.

Before this, commercial LPG rates were increased by ₹195.50 per 19-kg cylinder in April and by ₹114.50 in March.

The price of bulk diesel used by hotels, telecom towers, restaurants and industries was raised from about ₹137 per litre to over ₹149. Similarly, state-owned oil firms hiked jet fuel prices for international airlines by $76.55 per kilolitre (KL) from $1,435.31 per KL (Delhi).

CONSUMER SHIELD

This reflects the government's effort to balance the losses being incurred by PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs) due to the steep prices of crude oil, LNG and LPG due to the West Asia conflict, while shielding the common man from high volatility in the oil and gas markets.

India is heavily dependent on the Middle East Gulf (MEG) region for almost 90 per cent of its LPG imports, over 50 per cent of its liquefied natural gas (LNG) shipments and around 50 per cent of its crude oil consumption.

ICRA estimates domestic LPG under-recoveries at ₹80,000 crore in FY27, if current under-recoveries continue for the entire year. "At crude prices of $120-125 per barrel and long-term averages of crack spreads, the marketing margins on petrol and diesel are estimated to be negative ₹14 per litre and ₹18 per litre, respectively," the ratings agency added.

Commercial liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) is a deregulated commodity. It is market-linked, with prices revised monthly in line with the Saudi Contract Price (benchmark).

The 5-kg free trade LPG (FTL) cylinder is also sold from the commercial pool. It was launched especially for the migrant population in urban and semi-urban areas who do not have local address proof, people with lower gas consumption, and commercial establishments with limited space.

On Friday, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said, "OMCs have undertaken a calibrated price revision aligned with prevailing international trends for a small set of products catering primarily to commercial, industrial and premium segments, such as commercial LPG including both bulk and packed LPG, bulk diesel and ATF for international operations, which constitute a relatively minor share of total consumption and are subject to routine market-linked adjustments."

India's largest OMC, Indian Oil Corporation (IOCL), said: "As part of this consumer-centric approach, there has been no change in key fuels affecting the general public."

Also read **p3**

Capacity boost, GST 2.0, tax relief drive April PV sales to record high

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Helped by expansion of production capacities and new launches, passenger vehicle (PV) makers reported positive growth in their domestic wholesales (dispatches to dealers) on a yearly basis in April. Carmakers cited the tailwinds of GST 2.0, income tax relief and the reduction in repo rates as the main engines driving sales to an all-time high.

Overall, domestic PV sales were estimated to have grown 27 per cent to around 4.5 lakh units in April, compared with 3.54 lakh units in the same month last year.

Growth drive

Company	April 2025	April 2026	% change
Passenger vehicles			
Maruti Suzuki India	1,38,704	1,87,704	35.3
Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles	45,199	59,000	30.5
M&M	52,330	56,331	8
Hyundai Motor India	44,374	51,902	17
Kia India	23,623	27,286	16
Toyota Kirloskar Motor	24,833	30,159	21
JSW MG Motor India	5,829	6,018	3.2
Honda Cars India	3,360	4,069	21
Renault India	2,602	5,413	108
Nissan Motor India	1,825	3,203	75.5

Source: Companies/Industry Sources

RISING PENETRATION

The largest car-maker, Maruti Suzuki India Ltd (MSIL), recorded an all-time high monthly domestic sales of 1,87,704 units in April, up 35.3 per cent from 1,38,704 units in April 2025, bolstered by the expansion of two production lines at its Kharkhoda (Haryana) and Hansalpur (Gujarat) plants, which added 2.5 lakh units each to help meet customer demand.

"We have been working on getting closer to the customer, and in the last two years, we have opened one touchpoint every day across the country... We are now seeing dividends coming out of it. Our rural growth has been 39 per cent, and penetration has now gone to 52.3 per cent (a rise of 2.4 per cent)," said Partho Banerjee, Senior Executive Officer, Marketing and Sales, MSIL, adding that the network stock as of May 1 remains at 16-17 days.

He said the company had pending bookings of around 1.65 lakh cars at the moment.

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles took the No 2 position with domestic wholesales of 59,000 units in April, up 30.5 per cent compared to 45,199 units in April 2025.

M&M reported domestic wholesales of 56,331 units, up by 8 per cent over 52,330 units dispatched in the same month last year.

Hyundai Motor India (HMIL) said it achieved the highest-ever monthly sales for any April with domestic wholesales of 51,902 units last month, up 17 per cent compared to 44,374 units in April 2025.

"We opened the new financial year on a strong note... The encouraging response to our recent product interventions, including the new Exter, Verna, Ioniq5 and Creta Summer Edition, Grand i10 Nios Vibe Edition and Venue Knight Edition, has reinforced the competitiveness of our line-up," said Tarun Garg, MD and CEO, HMIL.

WIDE GAINS

Other carmakers such as Kia India, Toyota Kirloskar Motor, Honda Cars India and Nissan Motor India also reported double-digit growth.

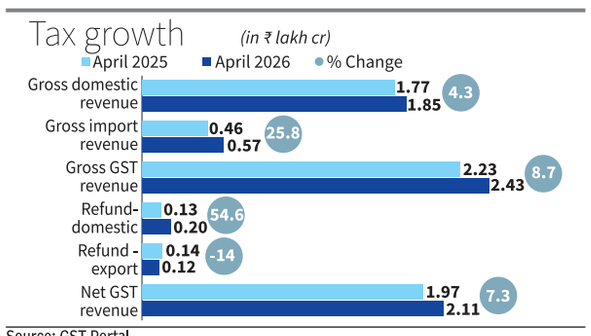
Also read **p2**

GST collections soar to a peak of ₹2.42 lakh cr in April

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With robust mop-up from imported goods and year-end stock clearances, the Goods and Services Tax (GST) collection in April surged to an all-time high of ₹2.42 lakh crore. Unlike previous years, this record collection in April was achieved without the compensation cess. Collections in the corresponding month of the last fiscal stood at ₹2.33 lakh crore, a year-on-year growth of 8.7 per cent.

Tax growth (in ₹ lakh cr)



Source: GST Portal

REVENUE MIX

Data from the GST portal showed that collections from domestic sources exceeded ₹1.85 lakh crore, registering a growth of 4.3 per cent. At the same time, gross import revenue stood at over ₹57,000 crore, reflecting a growth of 25.8 per cent. Total refunds rose by 19.3 per cent, taking the net collection to around ₹2.11 lakh crore, a 7.3 per cent increase over the corresponding month of the last fiscal.

Saurabh Agarwal, Tax Partner at EY India, said while the headline numbers were encouraging, the divergence between modest domestic GST growth and the significant uptick in import-linked collections warranted a strategic pivot. "In an increasingly dynamic global landscape, we must critically re-examine our policy frameworks to further incentivise domestic manufacturing and ensure 'Make in India' keeps pace with global supply chain shifts," he said.

REFUNDS SPIKE

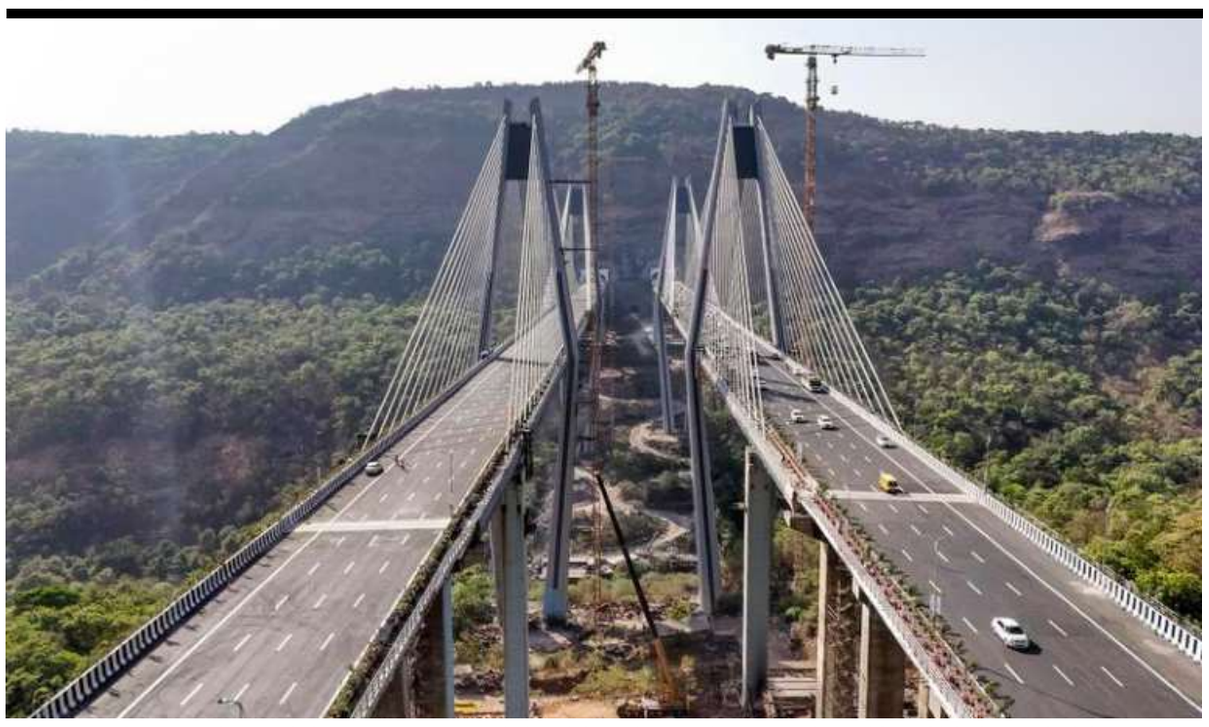
According to Vivek Jalan, Partner at Tax Connect, net domestic collections remained flat as refunds, primarily under the inverted duty structure, spiked 54 per cent. These refunds exclude the growing ITC accumulation on input services, which continues under GST 2.0's deepened inverted duty framework. "While this accumulation has maintained collections, it has simultaneously raised business expenses, a concern flagged to the GST Council for correction in its upcoming 57th meeting," he said.

However, Agarwal had a note of caution. April's record figures reflect the year-end push for targets by both industry and administrators.

"As we transition into the new fiscal year, we should anticipate a stabilisation in the coming months, with collections likely seeing a sequential dip in both absolute and percentage terms as the market recalibrates," he said.

Manoj Mishra, Partner at Grant Thornton Bharat, said the dominance of large, consumption-driven States such as Maharashtra, Karnataka, Gujarat and Uttar Pradesh highlights compliance depth and economic concentration.

MISSING LINK



ROUTE UPGRADE. The Mumbai-Pune Expressway 'Missing Link' project was inaugurated on Friday, which also marked the statehood day of Maharashtra. The much-awaited 13.3-km-long project connects Khopoli, in Raigad district, on the Mumbai side to Kusgaon, near Lonavala in Pune district, bypassing the steep mountain pass section, reducing travel time and improving road safety. It will make the 94-km expressway fully access-controlled, easing congestion in the hilly ghat section PTI

How rural economy around Bhogapuram airport is taking off

Villages transform with rising investments, employment and commercial activity

G Naga Sridhar
Bhogapuram

The rural landscape around the upcoming greenfield Bhogapuram International Airport in Andhra Pradesh's Vizianagaram district is undergoing a visible economic transformation, with a surge in local business activities, employment opportunities and real-estate demand ahead of its proposed inauguration in July.

Villages dotting the airport zone are witnessing heightened commercial activity, with small businesses emerging and land prices rising sharply as hospitality chains, real-estate developers and commercial players scout for land.

"For the last two years, economic activity has been gathering pace due to the pace of construction and the steady increase in visitor footfalls to the region.

LAST STRETCH. The main terminal of the airport, which is nearing completion. A 6-km highway link is also under construction G NAGA SRIDHAR

My earnings have doubled in the last six months," Vempada Ramana, a truck driver from Rajapuvalasa village, told *businessline*.

"There has been a noticeable rise in job opportunities for locals. My two sons, who completed their polytechnic courses, recently secured jobs linked to the airport ecosystem," said K Venkateshwarlu of Chepalakuncheru village.

"I am optimistic about the future. The customer footfall has been encouraging, and I have already reached break-even," said C Chandrasekhar, who recently set up a general store at Rellipeta, located opposite the airport's approach road.

LAND PRICES SOAR

The airport-driven economic activity has altered the region's real-estate dynamics. "Two years ago, land prices ranged from ₹1.5 crore to ₹3 crore an acre in most of these villages. With infrastructure works gathering pace, prices have now moved up to ₹5 crore-₹8 crore an acre," said RS Rao, a Visakhapatnam-based infrastructure developer.

Hospitality majors, too, are lining up investments. The Oberoi Group and Mayfair Hotels and Resorts are evaluating opportunities.

"The Andhra Pradesh government's new tourism policy and its faster pace of clearances are attracting investments into the region," a senior Industries Department official said, adding that Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu is expected to announce fresh investments in the region.

The completion of the airport remains a key infrastructure priority of the government, with it featuring prominently in the pre-poll commitments of the NDA alliance in the 2024 Assembly elections.

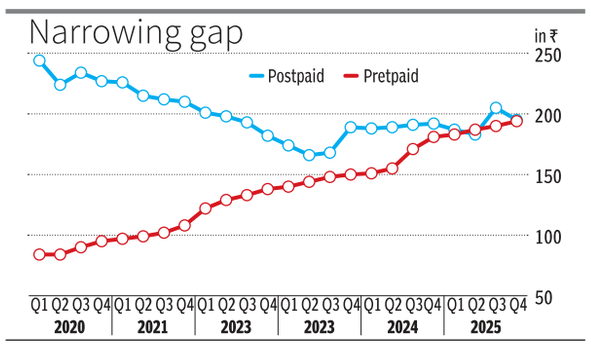
Prepaid-postpaid ARPU gap nearly vanishes, signalling major telecom market shift

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

For the first time since India's mobile revolution took hold, the gap between prepaid and postpaid average revenue per user (ARPU) has nearly disappeared as mass-market prepaid users now spend on a par with premium postpaid subscribers, per government data.

The ARPU gap that used to be as wide as ₹129, with prepaid at ₹84 and postpaid at ₹244 in 2020, is nearly gone, with prepaid at ₹194 and postpaid at ₹199 in the December quarter of 2025. The levelling signals a shift that could reshape postpaid pricing, premium positioning and subscriber acquisition strategies.

Narrowing gap



NARROWING GAP

"Particularly, the narrowing gap in ARPUs could lead to a downward trend in terms of mobile number portability in the coming months, compelling operators to consider offering handset bundling or even put pressure on operators to take a closer look at value-additions for postpaid services," Faisal Kawoosa, Chief Analyst and Founder of Techarc, told *businessline*.

Attributing the trend to the recent tariff hike, Kawoosa said, "In India, handset bundling never picked up because we had a substantial prepaid base. If the tariff is the same, then operators can raise awareness on this and invite more users to come to postpaid plans to see how handsets can be offered against contract."

TV Ramachandran, President, Broadband India Forum, said the trend may, in fact, encourage some migration from prepaid to postpaid to avoid the hassle of repeated recharges. "Postpaid is fixed always. If the prepaid advantage of lower prices is not there now, they may switch to postpaid. However, the trend is unlikely to sustain for long. Postpaid customers don't mind paying a little more."

DIFFERENT APPROACH

Mahesh Uppal, Director of Com First (India), said prepaid and postpaid customers have different motivations. Postpaid helps avoid regular recharges, while prepaid ensures transparency and budgeting. Asked if prepaid users should enjoy the same additional benefits as postpaid users, Uppal said the features of the two plans are very different, with distinct advantages. Even with the same ARPU numbers, the TRAI data do not show granular usage on how prepaid subscribers consume their packages.

"Prepaid does get its share of benefits in a different place. There are no major benefits that postpaid users get over prepaid users, other than avoiding disconnections if they miss a payment," he said.

BENGALURU
businessline.
SATURDAY - MAY 2 - 2026

QUICKLY.

Empower India signs term sheet to buy UAE's MABIL

Mumbai: Sustainable energy solutions provider Empower India Ltd (EIL) on Friday said it has signed a term sheet for the proposed acquisition of a majority stake in UAE-based MABIL. The transaction is structured as a strategic cross-border acquisition to be executed through a share-swap arrangement, the company said in a statement. PTI

NFRA sets up 4 separate functional divisions

New Delhi: The National Financial Reporting Authority (NFRA) has set up four separate functional divisions, including one for investigation and disciplinary proceedings. NFRA was set up in 2018 under the Companies Act. The four separate divisions are for monitoring oversight, investigation, determination and disciplinary, according to an order issued by the regulator. PTI

Post takeover, UltraTech drives turnaround at India Cements

CONCRETE RESULTS. ICL posts profit of ₹60 cr in Q4, trims net loss to ₹67 cr in FY26

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

In a sharp reversal of fortunes, cement major India Cements Ltd (ICL) delivered a turnaround in the final quarter of FY26. Its consolidated net profit saw an over four-fold jump on the back of volume growth and tighter cost controls with the takeover of cement giant UltraTech.

The pull of the UltraTech brand, benefits of full brand integration, change in product mix and reduction in expenses, including interest costs, have been the key levers behind ICL's revival. Prior to the takeover, ICL was hard pressed for working capital and operated at low capacity.

MORE OUTPUT. Capacity utilisation has increased even in the old plants of ICL such as those in Sankarnagar, Chilamkur and Yerraguntla BIJOY GHOSH

Q4 EARNINGS

ICL posted a net profit of ₹60 crore in the quarter ended March (Q4FY26), a sharp rise from the ₹15 crore in the same period last year. For FY26, the company trimmed its net loss to ₹67 crore from a loss of ₹144 crore in the same period last year. Industry sources and analysts told *businessline* that ICL's ability to keep costs low and increase capacity utilisation played the decisive role.

Capacity utilisation has increased even in the old plants of ICL such as those in Sankarnagar (Tamil Nadu), Chilamkur (Andhra Pradesh) and Yerraguntla (Andhra Pradesh), they said. UltraTech's logistics network also enabled ICL to source clinker and raw materials at lower cost for its plants while simultaneously reducing the cost of marketing, they added.

"There is also a change in product mix with UltraTech said to be leaning more towards Portland Pozzolana Cement (PPC) compared to Ordinary Portland Cement (OPC), which was used by ICL earlier. PPC is more economical in terms of production cost," said a cement industry veteran.

NO MORE UNIONS

On the HR front, sources say UltraTech has not undertaken major downsizing. "They have retained the human approach of ICL. But one major development is that UltraTech has done away with unions and their roles in ICL plants," the person added.

UltraTech has managed to bring the unit EBITDA to ₹497 per tonne, and will continue to target ₹1,000 per tonne EBITDA by end of FY28. UltraTech CFO Atul Daga said in the earnings call this week that 100 per cent brand migration was completed by March-end for ICL.

"Now, it will be one product, which will leave from all nine factories of India When compared to the earlier days, there were multiple cement brands going out... So, the real efficiency, in logistics, seamless operations will be visible now. My performance will go up further in terms of earnings potentials from India Cements," he said.

HEADWINDS

Insiders also confirm that ICL's erstwhile marquee legacy brands such as Sankar and Coromandel are not being sold any more. However, analysts note that rising logistics costs and petcoke prices are headwinds in UltraTech's ability to reach ₹1000/tonne EBITDA with India Cements, and there will be need for capex.

PV registrations dip 10%, but EVs show resilience; Tata leads: Vahan

T E Raja Simhan
Amit Vijay Mohile
Chennai/Mumbai

Passenger vehicle (PV) registrations declined 10.2 per cent month-on-month (m-o-m) in April to 3,98,146 units, while EV volumes slipped just 1.8 per cent, pushing electric vehicles' share to a new high of 5.7 per cent, according to Vahan data estimates.

The decline came after the year-end surge that had lifted March volumes to 4,43,201 units. In contrast, EV registrations showed greater resilience: volumes stood at 22,677 units in April, down only marginally from 23,097 units in March.

EV penetration rose to nearly 5.7 per cent of total PV sales, up from about 5.2 per cent the previous month.

The passenger EV market is witnessing a healthy transformation, said Gaurav Vangaal of S&P Global Mobility, adding that recent launches like the Maruti e-Vitara, Mahindra XEV 9s and Tata Punch EV underscore manufacturer commitment to electrification.

With Tata Sierra EV and upcoming launches from MG and Mahindra on the horizon, market penetration will deepen meaningfully. Crude oil volatility and West Asia tensions only reinforce EVs as a strategic hedge.

While Maruti is still establishing itself, the sheer number of credible alternatives arriving annually will drive industry growth and consumer confidence broadly, he said.

Broad-based decline *(in units)*

OEM	Jan-26	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26	Apr vs Mar %
Maruti Suzuki	2,18,740	1,56,428	1,75,160	1,58,223	-9.7
Tata Motors	64,797	57,877	67,162	57,472	-14.4
M&M	65,308	56,016	64,080	54,897	-14.3
Hyundai	67,110	46,632	49,933	47,345	-5.2
Toyota	36,495	27,939	28,991	26,779	-7.6
Kia	30,883	25,939	29,034	25,130	-13.4
Honda	6,007	4,928	5,710	5,326	-6.7
Skoda/VW	10,166	8,000	9,158	8,862	-3.2
MG	6,195	4,865	6,743	6,033	-10.5
Renault	4,868	3,291	3,637	4,079	12.2
Nissan	2,457	1,709	2,590	3,032	17.1
PCA	1,234	825	778	719	-7.6
Fiat	330	216	225	249	10.7
Industry	**5,14,590**	**3,94,665**	**4,43,201**	**3,98,146**	**-10.2**

PV DEMAND COOLS

Maruti Suzuki continued to dominate passenger vehicle retail with 1,58,223 units, accounting for nearly 40 per cent of the market, followed by Tata Motors (57,472 units), Mahindra & Mahindra (54,897 units), and Hyundai (47,345 units). Together, the top four automakers accounted for nearly 80 per cent of total retail volumes.

The decline was broad-based, with all major manufacturers reporting lower volumes compared to March.

The data point to a cooling in demand after the year-end push, with no major player registering growth at scale.

Nalinikanth Gollagunta, CEO, Automotive Division, M&M Ltd, said the company achieved SUV sales of 56,331 units in April 2026, a growth of 8 per cent, and total vehicle sales of 94,627 units, up 14 per cent over the same month last year. M&M's total vehicle figures include segments beyond passenger vehicles.

EV MELTS ICE

Poonam Upadhyay, Director, Crisil Ratings, said India's electric four-wheeler (E4W) segment opened FY27 on a sharp note.

April 2026 registrations came in at about 22,405 units, up 72 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y), signalling that momentum built at the tail end of last fiscal is carrying over.

Fuel price anxiety, triggered by disruption in global crude supply, has pushed fence-sitters to evaluate EV option.

Frequent launches with improved range have helped. OEMs have expanded into both mid-SUV and premium categories, bringing more buyers into consideration. Charging infrastructure is gradually improving.

Tata Motors led the EV segment with 8,507 units, or 37.5 per cent share. Mahindra & Mahindra followed with 5,394 units (23.8 per cent) and MG Motor with 4,978 units (21.9 per cent). The top three players together accounted for over 83 per cent of EV retail volumes.

THE SHIFT

The divergence between slowing ICE demand and steady EV adoption is likely to shape market dynamics in the coming quarters.

E4W penetration as a share of total PV sales currently stands at roughly 4-5 per cent. Fuel prices, policy continuity and new launches will shape the pace of growth. If current trends hold, penetration could reach 7-8 per cent by end of FY27.

Skoda VW shifts gear, positions India as global engineering hub

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

The Skoda Volkswagen Group is positioning India as a global engineering hub, with its 33,000 sq ft R&D expansion in Pune aligned with its 'Make in India, for India and the world' strategy, marking a shift from localisation to original product development for global markets.

NEW FACILITY

The Baner facility, alongside its Technology Centre Pune (TCP), established in 2019 at Chakan, will house over 250 engineers, taking Škoda Auto Volkswagen India's total engineering strength to over 450. The focus is now on designing platforms, software and digital features for both domestic and international markets.

"This is about giving India a stronger role in global development," said Piyush Arora, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of Škoda Auto Volkswagen India, describing the evolution as giving the country a 'voice of India' within the group's global ecosystem.

A company official said the Pune centre is being positioned as a lead development hub within the group, with India teams now driving work on global platforms, software architecture and future mobility programmes for multiple markets.

The shift is visible in the success of the MQB-A0-IN platform, the first vehicle architecture developed substantially in India, which underpins models such as Kushaq, Taigun, Slavia and Virtus.

The group has shipped over 700,000 vehicles from India to markets across Latin America, Africa, South-East Asia and West Asia GETTY IMAGES

Over 500,000 vehicles have been built on this platform, demonstrating that India-led engineering can deliver global standards, while remaining cost competitive.

India is also emerging as a key export base. The group has shipped over 700,000 vehicles from India to markets across Latin America, Africa, South-East Asia and West Asia, positioning the country as a hub for production and engineering-led global supply chains.

ADDING NEW LAYER

The expansion adds a new layer to this strategy, with a sharper focus on software development, digitalisation, automation and advanced safety technologies — areas that are becoming central as vehicles evolve into "computers on wheels".

By locating engineering teams in an urban tech cluster, the company is tapping into India's software talent pool to build next-generation infotainment, connectivity and driver-assistance systems. The group is working on adapting global electric vehicle architectures for local conditions such as heat and dust, while developing compact vehicle formats tailored to emerging markets.

Models such as the Kylaq, the group's first sub-4-metre SUV developed for India, highlight this approach, combining global safety and performance standards with cost-sensitive engineering.

The broader shift reflects how global automakers are rethinking India's role.

Instead of treating it as a standalone market, companies are increasingly using India to develop hardened products — vehicles engineered to handle extreme conditions and price constraints — which can then be deployed across similar markets worldwide.

Waaree plans ₹30,000 crore capex for fully integrated clean energy platform

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Waaree Energies is planning a ₹30,000 crore capital expenditure over the next 18-24 months to build a fully integrated clean energy platform even as the company reported strong March quarter earnings.

Speaking on the sidelines of the results, Chief Financial Officer Abhishek Pareek said the planned ₹30,000 crore investment marks a shift beyond solar modules towards a fully integrated energy transition platform.

"The important message is that we are building the organisation to integrate across the entire energy transition value chain. Waaree is no longer just a solar company," he said.

Of the planned investment, ₹2,000-3,000 crore has already been deployed, with construction underway across cells and batteries, and 80-85 per cent of the outlay expected over the next 18-24 months. The board has also approved raising of up to ₹10,000 crore through a qualified institutional placement (QIP) to support expansion plans.

Chief Financial Officer Abhishek Pareek

CELL CAPACITY

The expansion is centred on deep backward integration across the solar value chain.

Waaree is scaling cell capacity from 5.4 GW to 15 GW by December, while building 10 GW of ingot and wafer capacity, expected to be operational within 12-15 months. Module manufacturing capacity is set to reach 28 GW within six months, including an additional 2.5 GW being added in the US.

The investment is incremental to an existing base of about 25 GW of modules and 5 GW of cells.

The company has also taken a strategic equity stake in an Oman-based polysilicon facility, positioning itself among a limited pool of non-Chinese players with end-to-end integration — from polysilicon to modules — and further into power electronics, storage and EPC.

Beyond solar, Waaree is entering battery manufacturing with an initial 3.5 GW of lithium iron phosphate (LFP) cell capacity, scaling to 16.5 GW by FY28, with total storage capacity expected to reach around 20 GW.

Ola Electric sees 20% m-o-m growth in April

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Ola Electric has recorded month-on-month growth in April 2026, with registrations rising to 12,166 units, up from 10,133 units in March, according to Vahan data.

This represents a 20 per cent month-on-month (m-o-m) increase, building on the recovery momentum seen in March.

The company's performance stood out in a month when the broader electric two-wheeler industry declined by over 22 per cent m-o-m.

Ola Electric spokesperson said, "Registrations grew 20 per cent month-on-month even as the market declined sharply, making Ola the only leading EV two-wheeler brand to grow in April. The commercialisation of our indigenously developed 4680 Bharat Cells has boosted cost efficiencies."

The company noted that its electric motorcycle portfolio has also seen traction, especially in large motorcycle markets such as Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Madhya Pradesh. The Roadster X is steadily ramping up and emerging as a meaningful product in the electric motorcycle category.

Axis Energy plans to invest ₹30,000 crore in underground coal gasification project

M Ramesh
Chennai

Brookfield-backed renewable energy company Axis Energy Ventures is "about to acquire" technology for underground coal gasification, the company's Chairman and Managing Director, Kataru Ravi Kumar Reddy, told *businessline*.

The Hyderabad-based company was among the two companies, along with Reliance Industries, that won two coal blocks each for producing gas through underground coal gasification (UCG). The Ministry of Coal announced on Tuesday that Axis Energy bagged the "dip extension of Belpahar and Tangardihi East coal mines". The two mines are in Odisha.

Dip extension refers to a deeper part of an existing coal mine where mining becomes difficult. In such cases, converting the coal into gas is the only viable way to utilise it. Reliance Industries won Recherla and Chintalpudi mines in Andhra Pradesh. Axis Energy is a wind and solar developer, with 1.5 GW of commissioned projects, 8 GW under development and 30 GW more in the pipeline. It has joint ventures with Brookfield Asset Management, a Canada-based investor, for executing different sets of projects.

Acquiring the technology will help the company in this venture, said its CMD

Asked how the company, which has little experience in UCG, plans to execute such a technologically challenging project, Reddy said acquiring the technology would help. He said the nature of technology "is confidential as of now", but said he is "very, very confident" of its success. Reddy expects the mines to begin gas producing in 2-3 years.

UCG projects are typically capital-intensive. Reddy said Axis Energy envisages investments of about ₹30,000 crore, describing UGC as the need of the hour. He said the gas could be used either for power generation or for ammonia production.

HAL appoints Ravi K as CMD

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Ravi K has assumed charge as the 22nd Chairman and Managing Director of Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL), succeeding DK Sunil, who superannuated on April 30.

Ravi brings over 30 years of experience across aerospace and defence, manufacturing and electronics. Prior to this appointment, he served as Director (Operations) at HAL, where he led strategic planning and played a role in securing HAL's Maharatna status.

"My vision is to transform HAL into a globally competitive aerospace and defence enterprise, driven by innovation, artificial intelligence, operational excellence and people," said Ravi.

He has held leadership roles, including Executive Director and General Manager of the LCA Tejas Division, and Executive Director (Corporate Planning).

Ravi K (left) takes over from DK Sunil during the handover ceremony

During his tenure, he concluded contracts for HAL, including the supply of 180 LCA Tejas aircraft to the Indian Air Force and 156 LCH Prachand helicopters to the Indian Army and Indian Air Force, and is credited with operationalising the LCA Tejas fleet in the IAF.

He improved fleet serviceability through customer-focused initiatives, established data communication with IAF bases and created a Single Point of Contact (SPOC) for customer support.

He has worked closely on advancing the localisation content of the LCA Tejas programme and expanding production capacity in Nasik.

He also played a role in developing a manufacturing ecosystem by outsourcing fuselage assemblies to private sector partners.

His initiatives have diversified HAL into civil manufacturing and maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO), creating revenue streams and expanding HAL's market presence.

A mechanical engineering graduate from Malnad College of Engineering, Karnataka, Ravi is an alumnus of IIM-Ahmedabad, and IAS, Toulouse.

Syngene sees pipeline traction, bets on biologics for growth beyond FY27

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Syngene International reported a subdued March quarter, with profit impacted by one-off items and continued client-specific headwinds even as the management signalled improving underlying momentum and a strengthening pipeline.

The company posted a 16 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) decline in profit after tax (before exceptional items) at ₹153 crore for Q4FY26, while revenue rose a modest 2 per cent y-o-y to ₹1,037 crore.

The decline was largely attributed to exceptional costs, including employee-related expenses, and the ongoing impact of destocking by a key biologics client linked to Librela. MD and CEO Peter Bains, in a post-result investor call, said: "While the overall numbers reflect the continuing impact from a single large molecule biologics client, our underlying business continued to show steady momentum."

Syngene posted a 16% y-o-y decline in profit after tax (before exceptional items) to ₹153 cr for Q4FY26, while revenue rose 2% y-o-y to ₹1,037 cr

Sequentially, revenue grew 13 per cent in Q4. Margins remained under pressure, with EBITDA margin at 29 per cent against 34 per cent a year ago, hit by higher operating costs and investments in new units.

Syngene is positioning itself for long-term growth through investments in biologics and contract development and manufacturing (CDMO).

It highlighted increasing traction in its pipeline, particularly in biologics, with rising engagement from global pharma and biotech clients.

SCALING UP

The company is also scaling up its capabilities in emerging modalities such as antibody-drug conjugates (ADCs), peptides and oligonucleotides.

During the quarter, it commissioned a new ADC discovery lab and expanded its Bengaluru biologics facility.

Its Bayview facility in the US is also nearing operationalisation.

The management indicated that FY27 will be a transition year, with performance expected to remain broadly flat due to lingering client headwinds and facility ramp-up costs.

businessline.
Disclaimer: Readers are requested to verify & make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liable in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

Food, hospitality sectors see higher cost pressures post commercial LPG price hike

MAJOR IMPACT. Players across the industry are likely to pass on the cost pressures to some extent to end consumers

Our Bureaus

From eateries to packaged food, the third consecutive price hike on commercial LPG will have a direct as well as indirect impact on a wide range of sectors.

This comes at a time when companies are already facing heightened cost pressures across supply chains triggered by the West Asia conflict.

Players, especially in the restaurant industry, are expected to pass on the cost pressures to some extent to end consumers. The impact is expected to be even more severe for smaller and micro players.

SURGING PRICES. The latest round of hike of ₹993 per 19-kg commercial LPG cylinder comes soon after hikes of ₹195.50 in April and ₹114.50 in March PTI

MANUFACTURING COSTS

"The hike in commercial LPG prices will directly hit the overall manufacturing costs for packaged food companies by 1-2 per cent given the energy-intensive nature of processes like frying and baking.

"While some impact may be absorbed in the short term, sustained increases could lead to calibrated price adjustments or efficiency measures and even a gradual shift towards alternative energy sources. Stable energy pricing remains crucial for the sector's growth and competitiveness," a spokesperson for snacks brands Cornitos told *businessline*.

The latest round of hike of ₹993 per 19-kg commercial LPG cylinder, comes soon after hikes of ₹195.50 in April and ₹114.50 in March.

For the hospitality industry, this will lead to an "unprecedented" cost escalation. Restaurant industry players said they will need to hike menu prices by at least 10-15 per cent.

"With commercial LPG prices now having risen by a staggering ₹1,332 within just three revisions, the sector is facing an unprecedented escalation in operating costs at a time when businesses are already struggling with supply disruptions, reduced operational capacity and weakened cash flows.

For an industry where energy costs form a chunk of operational expenditure, this is nothing short of catastrophic.

Hotels and restaurants are among the largest consumers of commercial LPG, and this sharp increase will disproportionately impact the hospitality sector, particularly small and medium establishments, caterers and businesses dependent on large scale food production," said Pradeep Shetty, VP of the Federation of Hotel & Restaurant Associations of India.

He pointed out that this comes at a time when many eateries are operating with curtailed hours, limited menus and alternative cooking arrangements due to inconsistent supply and rising fuel costs.

Aroop Verma, Founder of Seven Hills Tower, said menu prices may rise 15–20 per cent at owned outlets, but standalone restaurants could see increases of 20–50 per cent.

"That will directly hit consumption, especially among students and working-class consumers who depend on affordable daily meals," he said.

"In a city like Mumbai, 40–50 per cent of office-goers and small business owners depend on *khau* gullies and local food stalls for daily meals — sandwiches, *roti-sabzi* or thalis that currently cost ₹120–170, depending on the location. If prices rise to ₹200–250, it will go beyond the reach of lower-income consumers and could severely impact small vendors who rely on this daily demand," said a food cart owner in Mumbai's Nariman Point area.

HOTELS HIT

A member of the Andhra Pradesh Hotels Association said already many hotels had stopped running in-house restaurants and were only offering stay.

"Today's steep hike will further lead to closure of restaurants and smaller eateries which will lead to job-loss of many workers. The hotels will have no choice but to increase prices," he added.

Tamil Nadu Hoteliers Association President M Venkatasubbu said the hike in prices will be a major blow to the hotel industry.

"We have asked restaurants to move towards induction, but it cannot happen quickly. Right now, only about 25 per cent of the cooking can be done through induction and the rest is still dependent on LPG supply. Moreover only 50 per cent of the restaurants right now are using induction," he said.

CONSUMER DURABLES

A senior executive with a consumer durables company pointed out that while the price hike in commercial LPG may not have a substantial impact for the industry directly but the impact on suppliers of components and raw materials will lead to an indirect impact on production costs.

Meanwhile, Ajay Sahai, DG, Federation of Indian Export Organisations, said, "For Indian exporters, particularly MSMEs in energy-intensive sectors like food processing, ceramics and glass, cost stability remains important for better planning, pricing certainty, and maintaining margins in an increasingly competitive global market."

Sources in Tiruppur said while there was no direct impact on garment manufacturing units, higher costs for dyeing units that use LPG will affect garment manufacturing units.

With inputs from Meenakshi Verma Ambwani, Amit Vijay Mohile, Sindhu Hariharan, Rohan Das, G Naga Sridhar and T E Raja Simhan

Govt to maintain budgeted ₹12 lakh crore capex despite global challenges: Vualnam

Our Bureau
New Delhi

V Vualnam, Expenditure Secretary

The prolonged West Asia crisis has led to fiscal stress and uncertainty, but the government remains committed to the budgeted ₹12.22 lakh crore capital expenditure in the current fiscal, Expenditure Secretary V Vualnam has said. The upcoming few months, the next quarter and the year ahead would be very difficult to envisage with lots of possible stress points, he stressed.

FISCAL STRESS

"So, the fiscal stress is indeed very much a reality, but at the same time the priority sectors... the capex would really be a priority item which we would like to preserve and ensure that it continues at the budgeted level," Vualnam said at the ICPP Growth Conference, organised by Ashoka University.

On a positive note, the Secretary highlighted that fiscal prudence has put India on a very good footing in the current unpredictable times.

KEY AREAS

Focus areas for the government's capital expenditure in FY27 are highways, railways, shipping, ports and urban development sectors, Expenditure Secretary said.

The current global uncertainties have created a challenging situation for India, and the government has been proactive in trying to tackle each situation with agility, he noted.

India's fiscal prudence has put the country on a very good stead in the current unpredictable times, he added.

"We will, on our part, be committed to see that the required funds are provided in spite of all the stress points that may come up," he said.

FISCAL DEFICIT

The FY27 Budget has pegged the fiscal deficit at 4.3 per cent of GDP, which is now seen at 4.5 per cent of GDP, following a downward revision in India's nominal GDP under the new series.

To contain retail prices of petrol and diesel from rising amid the ongoing West Asia war, the government has cut excise duties, which poses a risk of fiscal slippage.

The excise duty cut is estimated to cost ₹7,000 crore to the exchequer for 15 days.

Since the beginning of the war in West Asia on February 28, crude oil prices have soared to a four-year high of $126 per barrel on Thursday from about the $73 level before the war.

"The next few months, the next quarter and the coming year are indeed very difficult to envisage, lots of possible stress points," he said.

Tax buoyancy will also have been looked out for amidst these conditions, Vualnam said, which can further squeeze fiscal space.

India imports 60 per cent of its LPG usage, and of that, 90 per cent flows through the now closed Strait of Hormuz, the Secretary said.

No change in domestic ATF prices; global jet fuel rates revised up

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

In what comes as relief for domestic airline operations, state-owned oil marketing companies (OMCs) have kept aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices unchanged for scheduled carriers, while revising fuel rates upward for international airline operations in the latest monthly revision effective May 1.

The move forms part of a broader pricing approach aimed at insulating domestic consumers from recent increases in international fuel prices. *businessline* was the first to report on Tuesday that the Centre is likely to maintain the existing cap on ATF price increases for domestic operations, even as discussions continue on broader measures to ease mounting cost pressures faced by the aviation industry.

DOMESTIC ATF RATES

Accordingly, ATF prices for scheduled domestic airlines across metro cities remain unchanged following the latest revision.

In Delhi, ATF prices for scheduled domestic airlines stand at ₹1,04,927 per kilolitre. Similarly, prices in Kolkata remain at ₹1,09,450 per kilolitre, while rates in Mumbai are at ₹98,247 per kilolitre. In Chennai, ATF prices continue at ₹1,09,873 per kilolitre.

However, prices of bulk diesel and ATF for international airline operations have been revised upward as part of routine monthly adjustments. The development comes a day after the Federation of Indian Airlines raised concerns over elevated ATF prices and their impact on airline operating costs.

PRICING APPROACH. The prices of bulk diesel and ATF for international airline operations have been revised upward as part of routine monthly adjustments BLOOMBERG

FIA, which represents Air India, IndiGo, and SpiceJet, had sought government intervention on aviation fuel pricing.

According to FIA, fuel costs, which traditionally account for 30–40 per cent of airline expenditure, now make up nearly 55–60 per cent of operating costs.

The industry body had said airlines are struggling to sustain both domestic and international operations amid an unprecedented surge in ATF prices.

When contacted, airline executives said carriers may adopt a calibrated approach to international capacity deployment. Nevertheless, they pointed out that Air India, which has deployed the majority of its capacity in the international sector, may face the biggest impact from the rise in ATF prices meant for international flights.

businessline had earlier reported, quoting industry sources, that Tata Group-led Air India is planning to curtail operations amid rising jet fuel prices and operational challenges. The proposed reduction could affect 75–100 international flights.

EXPERTS' TAKE

Speaking to *businessline* from Mumbai, Jagannarayan Padmanabhan, Senior Director and Global Head Consulting at Crisil, said ATF cost intensity has increased from nearly 35–40 per cent of operating costs to around 40–45 per cent, creating pressure on airline margins.

Additionally, Padmanabhan said higher fuel costs are forcing airlines to seek improved yields through fare adjustments and tighter revenue management, while capacity deployment may become more selective with a focus on profitable routes.

He added that although travel demand remains resilient, profitability could remain under pressure and capacity growth may moderate in the near term.

Meanwhile, Mark D Martin of Martin Consulting said the government's decision not to alter domestic ATF pricing reflects resistance to airline lobbying around fuel costs.

In addition, Martin said that airlines have historically passed higher fuel costs to passengers through fuel surcharges, limiting the direct financial burden on carriers.

He added the impact of fuel price hike is ultimately borne by travellers, while airline financial pressures cannot be attributed solely to government fuel pricing decisions.

'Govt planning policy to push floating solar projects'

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government is working on a dedicated scheme to give a push to floating solar projects in the country, MNRE Secretary Santosh Kumar Sarangi has said.

The senior Ministry official made the remarks at the 13th Foundation Day of the National Solar Energy Federation of India (NSEFI) in the national capital on Friday.

"We are actively looking at ways in which land does not become a constraint for deployment of solar modules," Sarangi said in his address.

In terms of floating solar, the Ministry is looking at a scheme which will encourage the states to go for much larger-scale floating solar projects, which till now have not reached their desired potential. Under floating solar projects, solar panel systems are installed on water bodies, and they are more energy-efficient than land-based systems due to the cooling effect of water.

Coal India's output for April falls 9.7% to 56 million tonnes

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

Coal behemoth Coal India's total coal production for April witnessed a 9.7 per cent year-on-year fall to 56.1 million tonnes (mt) compared with 62.1 mt for the same period last year.

During April, coal offtake witnessed a 2 per cent y-o-y decline at 63.2 mt as against 64.5 mt in the year-ago period, according to CIL's stock exchange filing on Friday.

Notably, among the company's seven coal-producing subsidiaries, five subsidiaries witnessed a fall in their production for the first month of the current financial year.

Eastern Coalfield (ECL), Bharat Coking Coal (BCCL), Northern Coalfields (NCL), Western Coalfields (WCL) and Mahanadi Coalfields (MCL) registered a production decline of 9.5 per cent, 41.3 per cent, 23.6 per cent, 6.6 per cent and 13.9 per cent, y-o-y, respectively.

Current high pithead stock at the mines of CIL might have impacted coal production, industry observers told *businessline*. Currently, pithead stock stands at around 125 mt as against 106.78 mt as on April 1, 2025.

THE REASON. Current high pithead stock at CIL's mines might have impacted coal production, said industry observers PTI

E-AUCTION PRICE UP

Coal India said its e-auction price of coal increased by 51 per cent over notified prices in April. In March, the e-auction price rose by 45 per cent over notified prices.

Quantity offered during April stood at 30.55 mt, while quantity allocated was 11.77 mt. The quantity of coal allocated through the e-auction decreased 11.64 per cent on a month-on-month basis.

While Eastern Coalfield (ECL) and Mahanadi Coalfields (MCL) witnessed only 23 per cent of their offered coal getting allocated through e-auction in April, Northern Coalfields (NCL) and South Eastern Coalfields (SECL) saw 100 per cent and 79 per cent of their offered coal getting allocated, respectively, during the month.

Significantly, for the fourth quarter last fiscal, Coal India's sales, in terms of volume, under fuel supply agreement fell to 167.70 mt from 175.07 mt in Q4FY25. Realisation under FSA also decreased to ₹1,460.47 per tonne from ₹1,486.60 per tonne in the year-ago period.

E-auction sales during the fourth quarter last fiscal rose 27.63 mt, compared with 21.63 mt in Q4FY25. Realisation under e-auction, however, decreased to ₹2,202.63 per tonne during Q4FY26 from ₹2,363.79 per tonne in Q4FY25.

Maersk levies freight surcharge on Gulf routes

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Global shipping major Maersk has introduced an emergency freight surcharge on cargo to and from the Gulf region, significantly increasing logistics costs.

Industry sources said while there are no direct sailings currently operating reliably through the corridor, essential cargo such as pharmaceuticals and perishables are being routed through alternative sea-land combinations.

NEW STRUCTURE

Under the new structure announced by Maersk in a trade notice issued on April 27, shippers will pay $1,800 per 20-ft container, $3,000 per 40-ft container, and $3,800 for reefers, special and dangerous cargo. The surcharge applies to cargo originating from, destined for or transiting through affected Gulf ports. While the line did not specify the effective date of implementation, industry sources said it is with immediate effect.

The fee covers shipments linked to key markets including the UAE, Saudi Arabia (Dammam and Jubail), Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain, Iraq and parts of Oman.

The surcharge includes 14 days of storage in transit, after which additional storage and reefer plug-in charges will apply.

No relief for India as US retains 'priority watch list' tag over IP issues

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

The US has placed India once again on the 'priority watch list' of countries, alongside five others, including China and Russia, for alleged deficiencies in its intellectual property (IP) protection and enforcement.

The latest USTR Special 301 report on IP review shared on Thursday noted that among other concerns in India, the potential threat of patent revocations and the procedural and discretionary invocation of patentability criteria under the Indian Patents Act impact companies across different sectors, especially pharmaceuticals.

"The US intends to continue to engage with India on IP matters, including through US-India Bilateral Trade Agreement negotiations and the TPF's Intellectual Property Working Group," the USTR report stated.

Accepting US demands could weaken India's generics industry and raise drug costs worldwide, per an analysis of the review by Ajay Srivastava, Founder, Global Trade and Research Initiative (GTRI).

"Despite India's justifications of limiting IP protections as a way to promote access to technologies, India maintains high customs duties directed to IP-intensive products such as information and communications technology (ICT) products, solar energy equipment, medical devices, pharmaceuticals, and capital goods," the USTR report said.

IP ALARM. The USTR Section 301 report on IP cites concerns over potential threat of patent revocations

PRIORITY WATCH

India, while still on the priority watch list, remains in a category that emphasises ongoing bilateral engagement rather than immediate trade sanctions. Other countries classified as priority watch are China, Russia, Chile, Venezuela and Indonesia, while Vietnam was identified as a priority foreign country, the most serious classification under the framework. It leads to special investigations and possible trade action. The report acknowledged that India had made some meaningful progress in 2024 to promote IP protection and enforcement in some areas and took steps to partially address long-standing issues by notifying the Patents (Amendment) Rules, 2024, including provisions that are likely to increase the efficiency of the patent regime and reduce current burdens on patent applicants. However, patent issues continue to be of particular concern in India.

PHARMA SECTOR

In the pharmaceutical sector, the US continues to monitor the restriction on patent-eligible subject matter in Section 3(d) of the Indian Patents Act and its impact, the report noted. The US has long been seeking the revocation or dilute of Section 3(d) that sets a higher bar for patenting "incremental innovations" designed to prevent a practice known as evergreening, where pharma companies extend their patent monopolies by making minor, cosmetic changes to existing drugs.

"Pharmaceutical stakeholders also express concerns as to whether India has an effective mechanism for the early resolution of potential pharmaceutical patent disputes. In particular, India does not have a system to provide notice to a patent holder or to allow for a patent holder to be notified prior to the marketing of a follow-on product, which limits transparency," it said.

TRIPS-PLUS NORMS

The US is pushing for TRIPS-plus norms like data exclusivity and broader patent protection but India has been defending its regime as fully WTO-compliant and designed to ensure affordable medicines, Srivastava pointed out. "India supplies nearly 20 per cent of global generic medicines, making its IP stance globally significant. Accepting US demands could weaken India's generics industry and raise drug costs worldwide," he said.

BENGALURU
businessline.
SATURDAY - MAY 2 - 2026

QUICKLY.

BSA Scrambler 650 available at ₹3.25 lakh

Classic Legends has finally expanded BSA's retro portfolio beyond the Gold Star 650. The Scrambler is powered by the same 652cc, single-cylinder engine producing around 45 bhp and 5.5 kg-m, and is paired with a 6-speed gearbox. With 187 mm of ground clearance, a kerb weight of 208 kg, and suspension travel of 138 mm and 127 mm at the front and back respectively, it's positioned as a road-biased scrambler with light off-road capability.

Hyundai Ioniq 5 facelift launched in India at ₹55.7 lakh

The South Korean brand has updated its flagship electric offering in India, introducing the facelifted Ioniq 5 with notable upgrades. The biggest change is a larger 84-kWh battery replacing the earlier 72.6-kWh unit, pushing the claimed range up to 690 km. Subtle design tweaks, new alloy wheels and added features enhance the package, while it continues on the E-GMP platform as a premium, tech-heavy EV.

Morbidelli N125V unveiled with V-twin engine

Sino-Italian brand Morbidelli has unveiled its radical take on the entry-level naked segment. The N125V stands out with a 124.9cc, liquid-cooled V-twin engine producing around 13.8 bhp and 1.1 kg-m, paired to a 6-speed gearbox. Built on a steel-trellis frame with a single-sided swingarm, it packs premium hardware such as USD forks, traction control and dual-channel ABS, positioning itself as a more refined, high-spec alternative to conventional 125cc singles. Unfortunately, we won't be seeing this bike in India.

@TheMotorGram

KAIZAD ADIL DARUKHANAWALA

GS WHAT!

GREAT EXPECTATIONS. The Made-in-India BMW F 450 GS promises to bring proper GS vibes to the sub-500cc segment. Does it, though?

Kartik Ware

BMW Motorrad's GS lineup is easily its most prolific one, popular in India as well as the rest of the world; the G series had a single-cylinder engine, the F series carries parallel-twins, while the R series features BMW's famous boxer-twins. It's a combination of history, versatility and desirability that enables BMW to sell this family of do-it-all motorcycles by and to the droves. And now, we have the new F 450 GS, a motorcycle that replaces the G 310 GS while also superseding it in almost every aspect.

GS AGAIN

Designed by BMW but made by TVS Motor in India, the F 450 GS is a premium Motorrad machine in terms of build quality and equipment. It gets a 6.5-inch TFT screen connected to a rotary-scroll dial on the left side of the handlebar, a typical BMW touch, and the terminologies used in it are the same as the bigger GSes, too. There's an X-shaped headlight with all-LED elements, a detail that again connects it directly to its bigger siblings. The clutch and alternator covers are made of magnesium alloy which helps keep the motor's and overall weight down. And there are three variants: Base (₹4.7 lakh), Exclusive (₹4.9 lakh) and GS Trophy (₹5.3 lakh; all prices,ex-showroom). I rode the last one, which comes with all the bells and whistles, including an easy-ride clutch (ERC). A lot more on that later.

Headline numbers are as follows: a brand-new 420cc parallel-twin with a 135-degree crankpin offset makes 48 bhp at 8750 rpm and 4.42 kg-m at 6750 rpm, both sent to the road via a 6-speed gearbox. The motorcycle weighs 178 kg with a 14-litre fuel tank and a seat height of 845 mm. It comes with 19-inch front and 17-inch rear wheels with 100/90- and 130/80-section tyres, standard sizes for all-purpose motorcycles. Suspension travel stands at 180 mm at both ends, with a ground clearance of 220 mm. And BMW claims a top speed of 165 kph for it, which is more than is necessary in the real world.

Among electronic rider assists are a ride-by-wire throttle, a quickshifter, four ride modes (Rain, Road, Enduro and Enduro Pro), traction control, dynamic-brake control, engine drag-torque control and lean-sensitive ABS. Most of these features are standard across the variants, though some additions are available only on the Exclusive, while the GS Trophy gets all of them and then some. The F 450 GS also comes with heated grips as standard across all variants which, I think, is a bit too much in a mostly superheated country such as ours. And now for the most fun part.

ANYONE'S GS

Out on the road, far away from glorious spec-sheet claims and sky-high expectations, the F 450 GS left me nonplussed. Yes, it felt like a full-size motorcycle, roomy and comfortable yet manageable. But, for me, the ERC took away a significant part of the involvement of riding a motorcycle. Was it for a beginner, an expert or someone in between? It's a centrifugal clutch that engages at 2700 rpm; until then, at a standstill, you can row up and down the gearbox without touching the clutch lever, and the motorcycle won't budge.

Indeed, in the spirit of journalistic inquiry, I even made a standing start in sixth gear and the F 450 GS simply rolled away, whining like a big scooter. This is probably why the clutch-lever action is on the harder side; the internals necessarily have to be stouter to deal with less-than-considerate riding.

And after the screen is done flashing a message to shift to a lower gear, it'll tell you that the clutch is overheating, too. I didn't see the latter, though.

After putting the ERC at the back of my mind, the F 450 GS seemed more like a normal motorcycle. Most apparent was how it felt so light and nimble, turning and tightening its lines at will. The brakes were strong and inspired a lot of confidence; the front brake had a very sporty and powerful feel to it, not something usually seen on a dual-purpose machine. However, what came as a surprise was that the F 450 was not exactly GS-plush; even the previous G 310 GS was cosseting in its ride quality. Sure, the F 450 GS's suspension was strong enough to bash through everything in its path, but it transferred quite a lot of residual impacts to my body. That's not very GS-like, I must repeat, though it was always super-stable at all speeds. Even with the GS Trophy's adjustable suspension, which I didn't fiddle with, I don't see it becoming a two-wheeled cross-country sofa. I suppose it's just a matter of getting used to it if you buy it.

PREMIUM TOUCHES. There's no denying the quality and fit of the F 450 GS. The stickers certainly could've been better, though KAIZAD ADIL DARUKHANAWALA

As for the engine, I was again left with mixed feelings. I left it in Enduro mode for the duration of my ride, with the second-last level of safety assists, and it came across as quite a lively motor. It had a bit of a high-rpm-screamer quality when I really twisted the throttle, though the overall sound was nothing exceptional, even if it felt like a properly quick and fast motorcycle. Nonetheless, it was fairly smooth for the most part, though vibrations did surface at various points, especially after 6500-7000 rpm. At a steady 100 kph, though, it sat at a fuss-free 5500 rpm which bodes well for long-distance riding.

And it remained smooth and manageable at low speeds in traffic as well, the only niggle continuing to be the CVT-like rubber-band effect of the ERC.

Overall, the F 450 GS proved to be a motorcycle that's extremely easy to ride across a range of conditions. I only rode it off-road briefly, but I gathered that it has the hardware and electronics to acquit itself respectably in moderate off-road conditions, too. The gearshift quality, even with the quickshifter, was on the notchier side; I expect it to improve as it gets bedded in. Better tyres would be at the top of my to-do list if I ever bought the bike. Also, the quality of stickers on the bike wasn't what I was expecting on a bike in this segment, let alone a BMW. And the lack of colour options is a letdown, too; the Base and Exclusive only come in black, while the GS Trophy is the brighter one you see here. However, with that 14-litre tank, range should easily be upwards of 300 km, which is decent enough for long hauls. But basic competence is not the point of motorcycles like these in 2026, is it?

YOUR GS IS AS GOOD AS...

In the end, despite possessing all the right details, the F 450 GS lacked the sense of occasion that should come as standard equipment on such a motorcycle. I never once felt that I wanted this motorcycle right away. Its demeanour felt a bit out of character for a GS, honestly, and I expected it to be more than it is right now, especially given what it asks for. Does it change the mid-size game for BMW? Oh, yes. But for the segment?

That's a bit more complicated, since it doesn't set any outright standards on its own.

Also, the prices I mentioned earlier are introductory, so they will be revised upwards at some point. And BMW service costs do have a reputation of leaving wallets so empty, they echo. I'm not so sure a motorcycle made in India should be replicating what imported machines find unavoidable. But of course, there's no denying that the F 450 is a GS — after all, it comes with those BMW roundels that are impossible to brag or argue against. If you've been waiting for a relatively affordable Motorrad, this is the only option you have. Not much of a choice, if you ask me.

@TheMotorGram

MIGHT OVER MATTER

EYES ON THE PRIZE. The MG Majestor is an evolution of the Gloster done mostly right. Is that all MG had to do to take your mind off the Toyota Fortuner?

RUMAN DEVMANE

Ruman Devmane

How do you rival an SUV with an undying fanbase that exists for reasons beyond mere rationale? By drafting a simple-enough script and sticking to it. That's exactly what MG appears to have done with the Majestor, an SUV that retains all that worked for the Gloster it replaces and improves what didn't. It's a handsome machine, for sure. Large yet contemporary and with enough muscle courtesy its imposing grille, matte body claddings and 19-inch wheels. There is a full-size spare wheel, too, mounted on the underside of the boot. The cabin, an all-black affair, features tasteful bits of trim (the BMW-grille style air-con vents feel so chunky!) and ergonomically, it feels well laid-out. The 12.3-inch infotainment screen is slick enough, although it's dwarfed by the cabin width, and the UI is decent in its responsiveness. The gear-selector stalk is mounted behind the steering wheel, which allows for an elaborate two-tier centre console featuring spacious wireless charging pads, a pair of cupholders and ample stowage. There's Level 2 ADAS, too, and a comprehensive tech suite as you'd expect.

The mostly soft-touch materials add to the air of premiumness and quality is largely consistent. A more intent look, though, reveals questionable quality in some areas. On our test unit, the shroud behind the steering wheel, the removable cupholders and even the third-row seatback cladding appeared to be poorly assembled. I, for one, expect greater quality control for what is MG's ICE flagship — especially one that's set against the low-frills but hugely durable Fortuner.

ATTENTION, PLEASE! The spacious middle row experience is marred by the high floor. Interface and creature comforts tick the right boxes though the boot lid aperture requires caution RUMAN DEVMANE

DRIVER FIRST

With my six-foot frame, I also struggled to enjoy the middle row of captain seats, thanks to the high-set floor. While the seats are nice (ventilation and massage function only in the front row), you sit noticeably knees-up, therefore denying yourself any underthigh support. For shorter passengers, this may perhaps be acceptable and, surely, the dual-pane panoramic sunroof (with an electronically retractable sunshade) does amplify the largesse of the cabin. The third row is best reserved for kids, needless to say. How about a dedicated four-seater variant with a really impressive rear row of seats, MG?

On balance, the Majestor is more a driver-oriented SUV anyway. On that front, MG's 212-bhp twin-turbo 2.0-litre diesel engine delivers handsomely. It sure has the punch to hold its own on the highway and refinement levels are fairly decent, too. At expressway speeds, the Majestor feels relaxed and comfortably equipped for long driving distances. Low-speed driving isn't the most sophisticated or linear experience, though, especially courtesy the smooth but somewhat slow 8-speed gearbox (paddles available), but this eases out as you venture out onto the highway. A huge improvement over the Gloster is also the steering feel (there are three modes for this, too) and it now feels suitably well-weighted as opposed to the too-light mannerisms of its predecessor. A narrative the Majestor appears to want to dominate is off-roading. This explains why it has a pretty comprehensive off-road package, with a low-range transfer case, three differential locks, dedicated off-road driving modes and crawl control. In fact, MG also offers the Majestor with all-terrain tyres as an option. Over the curated off-road course MG had set up as part of the drive event, I figured the Majestor can tackle quite a high degree of off-road scenarios, although it will help if you know exactly what you're doing. Relying on its tech alone should see you through most reasonably challenging situations, though.

Why should you buy one? For its road presence, looks, front-row cabin experience, apparent ruggedness (durability is a long-term aspect which we can't comment on at the moment) and if you're the anti-incumbent type. Or, if Toyota's wait-list for the Fortuner is too long for your liking. What the Majestor doesn't command naturally is the credibility and peace of mind the Fortuner has earned through its years in service, and that's something MG can only attempt to change if it stays on its toes and commits to this segment for a long time.

@TheMotorGram

QUICKLY.

RBI says 98.47% of ₹2,000 currency notes returned

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank on Friday said 98.47 per cent of the ₹2,000 banknotes in circulation have been returned. The central bank announced the withdrawal of ₹2,000 denomination banknotes from circulation on May 19, 2023. The total value of ₹2,000 banknotes in circulation was ₹3.56 lakh crore at the close of business on May 19, 2023. PTI

Jindal Steel clocks over ₹1,000 cr net profit in Q4

New Delhi: Jindal Steel has posted a consolidated net profit of ₹1,041 crore during the quarter ended March 2026, on account of higher revenues contributed by "record sales." The steel maker had reported a loss of ₹304 crore in the year-ago quarter.
During the latest January-March period, the company's total income rose 25 per cent to ₹16,484.28 crore, from ₹13,254.94 crore in the fourth quarter of the preceding 2024-25, according to a statement. PTI

Market turbulence hits AMCs' revenue and profits in Q4FY26

WAY FORWARD. Analysts expect cut in total expense ratio to impact margins by 3-4 bps

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Volatile equity markets and growing geopolitical uncertainties have taken a heavy toll on asset management companies, with their revenue and profitability taking a hit on a sequential basis in the March quarter.

However, leading AMCs have managed to post better numbers year-on-year, largely due to steady inflows.

Going ahead, analysts expect the cut in total expense ratio to impact margins by 3-4 basis points even as fund houses are negotiating with intermediaries to pass on the incremental cost.

PROFIT FALLS

The net profit of all listed fund houses fell quarter-on-quarter. UTI AMC registered a loss of ₹67 crore in the March quarter against profit of ₹121 crore in the December quarter. Nippon AMC saw the lowest fall of 5 per cent at ₹384 crore (₹404 crore).

ON THE DECLINE. Net profit of all listed fund houses fell q-o-q

The rupee depreciation also had its impact on the overseas operations and the sharp fall in overall equity markets impacted earnings from passive funds.

On a year-on-year basis, except for Nippon MF and ICICI MF, all fund houses reported a drop in March quarter net profit.

HDFC MF reported 19 per cent increase in profit. Canara Robeco registered lowest fall in net profit by 0.2 per cent at ₹41 crore.

Shweta Rajani Head- Mutual funds, Anand Rathi Wealth, said despite the market condition in March quarter, top AMC companies delivered very strong results in FY26 with revenues growing much faster than costs.

The cut in TER is unlikely to have big impact in the near term as the overall industry is growing rapidly, with monthly SIP inflows above ₹30,000 crore and more investors from smaller cities entering mutual funds, she said.

However, cut in TER will be a bigger challenge for smaller AMCs without scale advantage or bargaining power on cost, while the larger AMCs may feel the pressure on margins rather than a threat to overall profitability, she added.

Revenue of Nippon MF and Canara Robeco MF were up 5 per cent and 4 per cent q-o-q at ₹739 crore and ₹114 crore, against ₹705 crore and ₹110 crore, while that of ICICI AMC was flat at ₹1,517 crore. Other MF houses, such as Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC and HDFC AMC, reported flattish revenue q-on-q, while UTI AMC reported a fall of 25 per cent in revenue as it registered a net gain on fair value changes of ₹107 crore in the December quarter.

However, y-o-y, all fund houses reported 7 to 30 per cent rise in revenue. Rajesh Singla CEO & Fund Manager Alpha AMC, said structural SIP inflows crossing ₹65 lakh crore in FY26 will give AMCs a durable revenue base that does not rely entirely on market returns to grow.

RBI told to reject Tata Sons' de-registration, order listing as upper layer NBFC by March

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Proxy advisory firm InGovern Research Services has urged the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to reject Tata Sons' March 2024 application to surrender its certificate of registration as a systemically important core investment company, and to direct the group to list as an upper layer NBFC by March 2027.

"For a holding company controlling ₹1.75 lakh crore in assets (including systemic listed companies like TCS, Tata Motors, and Tata Power), SEBI's LODR is essential to govern related party transactions (RPTs) and ensure that group-level capital allocation is transparent to the broader market," it said.

The proxy-adviser's three-point prescription — a public rejection of the deregistration bid, mandatory listing directive and immediate adoption of a ₹1 lakh crore asset threshold for upper layer classification — is formulated as necessary to preserve regulatory consistency

and protect minority shareholders. "The RBI must issue a definitive, public order rejecting the March 2024 application for de-registration of Tata Sons," the report stated.

RBI'S CIRCULAR

It said based on the analysis of the RBI's draft circular on amended eligibility criteria to be classified as an upper layer NBFC, and further directions issued by RBI on regulatory framework for NBFCs not availing public funds, Tata Sons application for re-registering was dead on arrival.

It also took note of an exhaustive list of NBFCs registered with the RBI, issued on April 10, which includes upper layer NBFCs such as Tata Sons. This is the same list as last year and the RBI has still to issue an updated list this year.

CIC STATUS

The InGovern note said the company's attempt to shed its CIC status by repaying standalone debt and claiming "no public funds" is legally and practically untenable under the scale-based regulation (SBR) framework.

The advisory highlights the RBI's April 29 clarification that equity infusions from group entities cannot be treated as purely "owned funds" because of leverage, multiple layers and fungibility, a position that InGovern says undermines Tata Sons' standalone deleveraging defence.

The firm pointed out that Tata Sons' cross-holdings — roughly 13-14 per cent held by listed Tata Group companies such as Tata Steel, Tata Motors and Tata Power — created a permanent look-through link to public funds. That structural linkage means the parent cannot lawfully claim exemption from listing obligations that apply to entities of systemic scale.

Indian banks will need to evolve as market-makers globally: RBI Guv

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Friday said Indian banks will need to evolve as market-makers globally if the global INR (Indian rupee) market has to be on-shored.

Indian banks are dealing only with offshore market-makers rather than with end-users, said Malhotra in his keynote address at the 25th FIMMDA-PDAI Annual Conference in Amsterdam.

The Governor said: "We will also stand prepared to deploy appropriate policy measures, as warranted, to mitigate spillovers and ensure orderly market conditions."

This observation comes in the backdrop of the rupee breaching the 95 to the dollar mark in intraday on Thursday for the first time since March 30, 2026, and closing at an all time low of 94.91 per US dollar.

The rupee has been buffeted by a host of factors, including global crude oil prices recently touching a four year high amid the ongoing West Asia war and blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, and persistent Dollar outflows due to FPI related sales in the Indian equity markets.

Malhotra emphasised that all banks should facilitate this as a priority, so that retail users get a fair deal. Currently, usage of the FX Retail platform remains limited.

The aforementioned suggestions form part of five areas for further deepening and strengthening India's financial markets.

RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra

The Governor said while central government securities market is liquid by most standards, there is scope to improve liquidity across all tenors and securities.

Malhotra noted that over-the-counter derivatives markets, especially interest rate derivatives, remain concentrated in just one or two few products.

He underscored that it needs to improve if efficient interest rate hedging options have to be made available to stakeholders.

He observed that development of credit derivatives, which is largely an underutilised area, is yet to take off in any meaningful way.

The Governor said market participants must acknowledge that while a privilege bestows some benefits, it also entails responsibilities.

The responsibilities include ensuring that every user has easy access to financial markets; can transact on fair and transparent terms, irrespective of size and sophistication; broader regulatory objectives are met in letter and spirit even as organisational interests are pursued; and to protect, promote and sustain market integrity.

Not worried about remittances, says RBI Deputy Governor

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

RBI Deputy Governor Poonam Gupta on Friday exuded confidence that inward remittances to India will not be impacted despite the West Asia crisis, and that the country's balance of payments (BoP) will be comfortable.

"India's BoP has some inherent strengths... two are on the current account side, and one is on the capital account side. Our remittances are solid at $135 billion plus, only move in one direction, which is a healthy growth every single year; even during Covid, they declined by a tiny bit," she noted.

Services exports are doing very well and also FDI inflows. These are structural strengths, which means despite shocks these strengths would be there, she said at the ICPP Growth Conference.

However, portfolio flows have been weaker than in the past, which has been countered by other parts of the balance of payments.

PE-VC investments down 32% in April

Rohan Das
Chennai

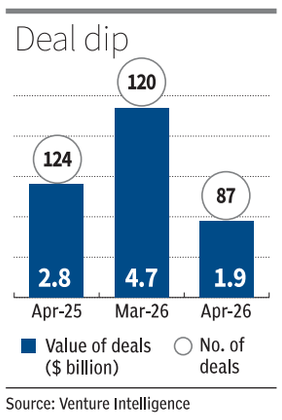
Private equity-venture capital (PE-VC) investments dropped 32 per cent year-on-year in terms of value in April 2026 at $1.9 billion against $2.8 billion in the same month last year, as per data from research firm Venture Intelligence.

The volume of deals also saw a similar decline, down 30 per cent from 124 deals in April 2025 to 87 in April 2026. Sequentially, the value of deals nearly halved this month, from the $4.7 billion in investments across 120 deals in March 2026.

MEGA DEALS

Overall, PE-VC investments in the first four months of 2026 stood at around $12 billion across 435 deals against $14.6 billion across 467 deals in the same period last year.

The value of mega deals



Source: Venture Intelligence

(over $100 million) also went down $1.1 billion invested in six such deals as against $1.9 billion across seven deals in April 2025.

Arun Natarajan, Founder, Venture Intelligence, said that while April saw six large deals, the largest deal recorded during the month was much smaller than the top mega deals witnessed in Q1FY26, led by investments in IPL team Royal Challengers and those attracted by data centre firms Neysa and Nxtra. The largest deal in the month was the $280 million that digital lending firm Kreditbee raised from Motilal Oswal Alternates, Advent International and PremjiInvest, among others. Apothecon Pharmaceuticals' $270 million raise from Everstone, and hospital chain Baby Memorial Hospital raising $186 million from KKR were the other major deals.

MARKET SLOWDOWN

Investments in early-stage companies went down to $253 million across 40 deals, while growth stage investments stood flat at $520 million across 26 deals.

Late stage investments also went down sharply to $376 million from $653 million.

The average early stage deal size doubled to $6 million against $3 million in April 2025. For growth stage, it went up to $20 million($12 million) and late stage saw a drop to $25million ($33 million).

IRAN WAR

Vikas Choudhary, Founding Partner at Playbook Partners believes that while the US-Iran war has not necessarily stalled deals, it has added more time and caution to investor decision making. He added that venture firms are sitting on cash and giving themselves more time to evaluate the impact of the situation.

"With historically high dry powder, the ecosystem remains active, but clearly more disciplined and selective. Geopolitical uncertainty might add time and caution, but it is not expected to reduce capital deployed," he said.

Natarajan added that the prolonging of the US-Iran war can impact the funding of some tech start-ups that were expecting to IPO during the year.

Exit polls may lift markets briefly, but oil remains key risk for equities

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The equity markets may get a short-lived sentiment boost from the exit polls even as global oil prices and domestic macro pressures remain the key drivers of market direction.

Exit polls for Assembly elections across Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal and Puducherry broadly indicate status quo outcomes, with incumbents expected to retain power in most regions and a tight race in West Bengal. For markets, this translates into a fleeting sense of stability rather than a decisive trigger, according to Kotak Institutional Equities' latest strategy report.

"Markets may continue to debate more on oil versus macro-calculus, while giving a brief cheer for electoral stability," said the report.

However, it cautioned against over-reliance on such projections. "Exit polls have had a mixed track record in India recently," it said as seen in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections and a growing reluctance among voters to disclose preferences.

Exit polls indicate the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) retaining Assam and Puducherry, the UDF returning in Kerala and the DMK-led alliance continuing in Tamil Nadu. West Bengal, however, remains too close to call, with the possibility of a tighter-than-expected outcome.

DURABILITY TEST

Even if election outcomes align with projections, the upside for equities may be capped. Kotak expects any rally to fade quickly as investors refocus on more

pressing concerns. "The durability of any rally will be tested quickly, as the trajectory of crude oil remains the single largest short-term risk variable," it said.

With no major State elections scheduled until early 2027, the Centre is entering what the brokerage describes as an "election-free corridor" of about 10 months —potentially allowing policymakers to shift focus to economic management. "Government enters a relatively election-free corridor... may firmly focus on managing India's weakening macro environment," the report said. The government is likely to prioritise managing a weakening macro environment marked by elevated crude prices, risks to food inflation from an uneven monsoon and a widening current account deficit.

Policy responses could include rationalising energy subsidies, accelerating trade diversification and pushing ahead with the proposed India-US bilateral trade agreement. For equity investors, however, the near-term playbook remains cautious.

The brokerage expects markets to trade in a narrow range as optimism from elections gives way to fundamentals — earnings growth, oil prices and policy action on fuel pricing.

UPI growth steadies after March peak; daily volumes hit record high in April

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions saw a marginal dip in April 2026 after hitting an all-time high in March, but underlying momentum remained strong with record daily volumes, according to data from the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI).

The payments network processed 22.35 billion transactions worth ₹29.03 lakh crore in April, down slightly from March's peak of 22.64 billion transactions worth ₹29.53 lakh crore.

The sequential decline was expected given that April has 30 days as compared to 31 in March, and follows the typical financial year-end surge.

On a year-on-year basis, however, growth remained robust. Transaction volumes rose 25 per cent, while value increased 21 per cent, signalling continued expansion of the digital payments ecosystem.

ROBUST GROWTH

More notably, daily run rates improved. UPI recorded an average of 745 million transactions per day in April, up from 730 million in March, while average daily transaction value stood at ₹96,766 crore.

The rise in daily volumes suggests sustained user engagement beyond seasonal spikes.

The March quarter had seen a sharp jump, with UPI handling 20.39 billion transactions worth ₹26.84 lakh crore in February before surging to record levels in March and easing slightly thereafter.

The rise in daily volumes suggests sustained user engagement beyond seasonal spikes

The ecosystem continues to be dominated by PhonePe and Google Pay. PhonePe crossed 10 billion transactions in March, capturing around 45 per cent market share, while Google Pay processed about 7.5 billion transactions, accounting for roughly a third of the market. Paytm trailed with about 1.7 billion transactions.

Industry executives said the April dip reflects normalisation rather than any slowdown in adoption.

Aakash Sinha, Co-founder and CEO of Cashfree Payments, said the moderation was largely due to March's year-end spike, adding that daily transaction growth is a more reliable indicator of demand."The slight dip is more a function of March's surge. What stands out is the increase in daily volumes, which shows underlying demand is still rising. We're also seeing higher-value transactions grow faster, indicating that users are increasingly relying on UPI for more meaningful spends," he said.

Share.Market names Vijay Ajmera to head business amid leadership rejig

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

PhonePe's broking arm Share.Market has appointed Vijay Ajmera to lead the business, according to people aware of the development, marking a leadership transition as the company sharpens its focus on wealth and trading vertical.

Ajmera takes over after Ujjwal Jain, who previously headed Share.Market, stepped down to pursue a new venture. Ajmera, a long-time PhonePe executive, had earlier founded a fintech lending firm before joining the Walmart-backed company.

As part of the rejig, mutual funds vertical head Nilesh Naik and chief investment officer Sujit Modi will report to Ajmera, the sources said.

Jain and Modi were among the founders of OpenQ, one of the wealthtech platforms acquired by PhonePe.

Confirming his exit in a social media post, Jain hinted at his next venture. "An AI-first world is rewriting every industry — and capital markets and wealth management are no exception. I am going in with more boldness, more clarity and more fire than ever before," he said.

Bengaluru-based PhonePe had entered the wealth management space through the acquisition of WealthDesk and OpenQ in 2022 for around $70 million. These platforms were subsequently integrated to build its stock market investment offering under the Share.Market brand.

The platform has steadily scaled since launch and is currently the 19th largest broking firm in the country, with about 2.2 lakh active investors, according to data from the National Stock Exchange.

The leadership change comes at a time when PhonePe is recalibrating its broader strategy. On March 16, the company said it had temporarily deferred its plans to go public, citing geopolitical tensions and volatility in global capital markets.

The fintech major added that it will revisit its listing plans once market conditions stabilise.

FPIs pull out ₹60,847 crore in April

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Foreign investors continued their relentless sell-off in Indian equities, pulling out ₹60,847 crore in April, primarily due to escalating geopolitical and macroeconomic uncertainties that dampened risk appetite.

With the latest withdrawal, total outflows by foreign portfolio investors have surged to ₹1.92 lakh crore in the first four months of 2026, significantly exceeding the ₹1.66 lakh crore outflow recorded in the entire calendar year 2025, according to NSDL data.

FPIs remained net sellers in 2026 except February. They withdrew ₹35,962 crore in January and infused ₹22,615 crore in February, the highest monthly inflow in 17 months.

BENGALURU
businessline.
SATURDAY - MAY 2 - 2026

the hindu businessline.
SATURDAY - MAY 2, 2026

Bad policy

Govt making a mistake by not raising fuel prices

The Centre increased commercial liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) prices by a massive 50 per cent or by ₹993 per 19 kg cylinder on Friday. What it did not do though was increase retail prices of domestic LPG, petrol and diesel, as was widely expected. With crude oil prices soaring over the last two months due to the Gulf war, the expectation was that fuel prices would be raised once the Assembly elections were over. But the Centre has preferred status quo for now. That's bad policy.

India's crude oil basket, a mix of different varieties of crude that the country sources, rose from $71 a barrel on February 28 when the war began, to $112 a barrel on May 1, with a high of $146 a barrel in mid-March. The international traded price of petrol (FOB), which was an average of $75.28 a barrel in February rose to $127.49 in April. Yet, petrol (and diesel) prices have remained unchanged in India; elsewhere in the world, they have become expensive, reflecting prevailing market prices. This is a puzzling policy stance. The Centre's resolve to not burden the common man with higher fuel prices is laudable but it flies against the reality of the markets. For a country that is 87 per cent dependent on imported crude oil, it is impossible to buffer the consumer from rising import costs forever. If costlier crude is not reflected in retail product prices, who's bearing the burden? The Centre absorbed some of it by cutting excise duty on petrol and diesel in late March, but that is insignificant when compared with the increase in sourcing costs.

The oil marketing companies — Indian Oil, Bharat Petroleum and Hindustan Petroleum — are acting as sponges soaking up the higher prices but the sponges, though strong, will begin to fray sooner than later because the losses they're soaking up are more than what they can handle. A recent ICRA report put the under-recoveries on LPG alone at ₹80,000 crore in FY27. The reality is that oil prices are unlikely to retrace their steps over the next few months. The Centre should accordingly plan for an equitable sharing of burden between oil companies, consumers and itself. It is poor policy to burden just one stakeholder. As even a freshman economics student would know, fuel demand is quite price elastic, and consumers need to feel the pinch of higher prices if demand is to be managed. The "protection" of consumers now will come back to haunt the Centre as demand remains unaffected, increasing the subsidy burden and straining the fisc, not to speak of the impact on the already beleaguered rupee.

Political compulsions are obviously behind the decision to hold retail prices, which is understandable. But good politics does not always sit well with good economics. The NDA government missed more than one opportunity to free prices (and be relieved of the political baggage) when oil prices touched lows several times in the last decade. If consumers had tasted low prices then, they would understand higher prices now when they are peaking. There is surely a lesson here for the future as the oil price cycle will surely turn again once the war ends.

POCKET: The Summer of '26

RAVIKANTH

Should MPC have hiked rates?

MISSED OUT. High inflation expectations, leveraged asset demand and a depreciating rupee are good reasons to hike rates

ABHIMAN DAS
SMITA ROY TRIVEDI

The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) has decided to hold the policy rates unchanged in the April monetary policy, which remains largely in consonance with market expectations. In the last few months, as conflict in West Asia intensified and fuel pangs were brought home, two differing views emerged on the likely impact on India: first, our economy is resilient and domestic demand-driven which will keep it afloat and on track of growth trajectory even with rupee declines; and second, the current account deficit and rupee woes will jeopardise the growth dynamics.

Both the views can be tempered and calibrated with an integrated view of domestic forward-looking indicators and external sector dynamics. First, firm level forward looking indicators clearly suggest a build-up of inflation expectations. With rupee depreciation and consequent rising fuel costs would impact firms first, making them the primary transmission channel of external shocks.

The latest data from Business Inflation Expectations Survey (BIES), conducted monthly by IIMA, that polls a panel of business leaders about their inflation expectations in the short and medium term, shows a marked increase in inflation expectations.

INFLATION EXPECTATIONS

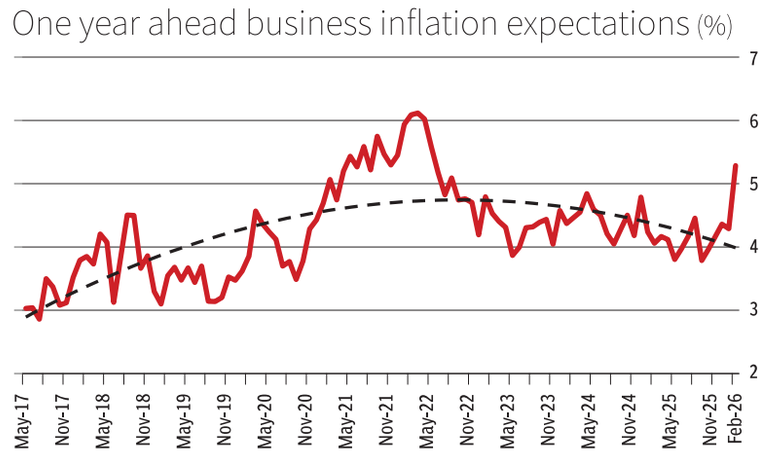
The one year ahead business inflation expectation recorded in March 2026 has shot up sharply by 100 basis points (bps) to 5.29 per cent, from 4.29 per cent recorded in February 2026. This is the highest ever monthly increase during the past nine years of the BIES. The trajectory of one year ahead business inflation expectations is presented in Chart 1.

The uncertainty of business inflation expectations has remained elevated by over 2 per cent during February-March 2026. The RBI in its monetary policy statement has also projected one year ahead CPI inflation to be in the range of 4-5 per cent with an upward risk.

The latest data shows Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation climbed to a 13-month high of 3.4 per cent in March an increase from the 3.2 per cent recorded in February (*businessline*, April 13, 2026).

CHART 1

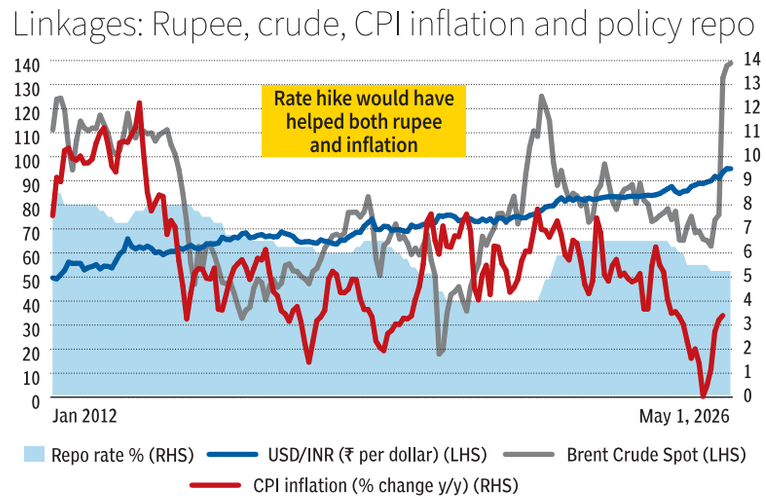
One year ahead business inflation expectations (%)



Source: BIES, IIMA

CHART 2

Linkages: Rupee, crude, CPI inflation and policy repo



Source: LSEG, Authors' annotations

> **The only way to prevent inflation from thwarting the limited growth prospects in the medium term is targeting inflation** first. Immediate growth sacrifice is a better option before inflation becomes deeply entrenched

Second, the crude prices remain the primary cause of concern, with Chart 2 showing how closely crude is tied to India's inflation figures and rupee depreciation. The supply shock feeds into both domestic growth and exports given the import dependence of export industries. There is no immediate supply side solution to this. With linkages to disposable incomes, firm performance and agricultural sector through fertilizer prices, crude shock directly feeds into consumption expenditure and hence growth. While the situation tends to be stagflationary, doing nothing and waiting for prices and wages to adjust in the labour market may not be the best option at this point in time. The historical experience suggests a rate cut or rate pause at this stage may not have desired impact. The 1970s experience clearly indicates the only way to prevent inflation from thwarting the limited growth prospects in the medium term is targeting the inflation first. Immediate growth sacrifice is a better option before inflation becomes deeply entrenched.

Globally we are seeing a move towards a hawkish tilt, with both Federal reserve and ECB holding rates steady yet cautioning against inflation driven risks. Markets are repricing this possibility of tightening, and Bank of Japan continues with a tightening phase.

WHY INTEREST RATE HIKE

There are two reasons at least why an interest rate hike would have been the right approach: First, as iterated by the RBI Governor, while credit growth has improved consistently, higher credit offtake might suggest either overoptimistic exuberance or leverage building. This would therefore be the right time for countercyclical policies. With sectors like real estate, gold and personal loans continuing to lead credit growth, a possibility of over-exuberance in face of inching inflation and muted growth suggests tightening would be prudent.

Secondly, a rate hike would have helped to stall rupee depreciation. Interventions with regard to the rupee generally need to be kept to a minimum. First, not only would spot market interventions reduce liquidity, it could push up inflation if followed up with liquidity infusion measures. Second, forward market interventions would build up dollar liabilities in the future, which given the geopolitical situation can be avoided.

Indirect intervention measures to regulate actions of market participants can lead to greater speculation. However, a rate increase would not only encourage foreign capital inflows, but help banks to make policies like FCNR (B) more attractive to attract capital flows.

Thus, a tilt on the hawkish side would have been more consistent with the flexible inflation targeting framework.

Das is ICICI Bank Chair Professor, IIM Ahmedabad, and Trivedi is Associate Professor, National Institute of Bank Management (NIBM). Views are personal

Manufacturing penalises experienced workers

With wage progression favouring younger workers, the sector will struggle to retain skilled, middle-level workers

Jayanta Talukder

Worker protests across India's industrial belts have again become a recurring feature of the economic landscape. The demands are rarely unexpected — a living wage, basic job security and some assurance that spending years on the factory floor will amount to something.

The protests appear to be triggered more by structural issues than by inflationary spike in energy prices or localised disputes over contract terms. In the manufacturing sector, the longer the workers stay, the less they are rewarded. The inversion of labour productivity/wage for low- and medium-skilled workers in their middle years is being hidden under the carpet in our zeal to employ the emerging youth population.

This is one of the more underappreciated vulnerabilities in India's industrial economy, and is becoming harder to ignore. Per PLFS 2025 data, the average salaried manufacturing worker earns ₹18,735 per month, and a monthly income of ₹22,500 places a worker in the top 20 per cent of this group (PLFS, 2025). The bar for relative prosperity is seemingly very low. This is compounded by lack of written contracts (16.5 per cent workers), social security (20.4 per cent) or paid leave (21.1 per cent), and self-employed workers in manufacturing (44 per cent) who have none of these and earn less than the average manufacturing worker.

The wage statistics are worrisome when we cut across demographics. The 2025 PLFS report shows workers in the 15-18 age cohort in manufacturing earn above (₹9,900 per month) their cohort's all-industry average (₹8,800), and enter the market with a competitive edge.

This advantage declines with age as manufacturing workers in their 40s earn almost 20 per cent less (₹21,150) than their all-industry average (₹26,000). Ignoring the negligible real wage gain, a manufacturing worker with 20 plus years of experience earns a little more than twice of what a teenager earns.

Standard human capital theory is also ignored, as the sector seemingly treats older workers not as repositories of accumulated skill but as costs to be managed downwards.

SENIORITY NOT REWARDED

The blame may not lie on any lack of demand for high-skilled manufacturing workers but rather on contract worker arrangements. By design, contract workers are not necessarily rewarded for seniority, they have no increment by tenure or pathway to permanence, allowing contractors to suppress wage growth over time.

The Annual Survey of Industries (ASI) 2023-24 report shows the share of workers employed through contractors steadily increasing from 38 per cent to 42 per cent over the last five years. Older workers are also more likely to be displaced by younger cohorts who are cheaper to employ, without adversely troubling the needle of output or productivity for the employer.

CONTRACT WORKERS. Steady rise in their share in employment REUTERS

In the new post-pandemic era of global fragility and national uncertainty, where input cost shocks are likely to occur with greater frequency, a manufacturing worker cannot accumulate purchasing power over the most productive years of their life, giving rise to a workforce permanently close to the edge. A single health shock is likely to compress household budgets even further.

The all-India PLFS numbers also inherently show inter-State labour migration is no magical escape route, but simply an age-old means of leaving villages and towns bereft of opportunities.

These findings should similarly warn young workers entering manufacturing at competitive wages only to gradually discover the sector offers little upward trajectory. Without adequate skilling, either self-motivated or institutionalised, they will soon be earning less in relative terms, than when they started. The demographic dividend may be achieved but at a higher cost for the next generations to come.

The new Labour Codes, especially the Industrial Relations and the Code on Wages, can enforce hard lines in contractual arrangements to avoid more casualisation of the workforce.

The national floor wage requires periodical revision to arrest wage suppression at lower ends of the distribution. Industrial policies can also incorporate wage progression benchmarks as explicit conditionalities, ensuring it reaches sector-specific workers who need it the most. State-level framing of the Codes will also become more critical to the success of such worker protection measures in due course.

Manufacturing is not a peripheral concern in India's growth story. With agriculture shedding surplus labour and services unable to absorb workers into 'good jobs', it remains a singularly important pathway to employment for India's low- and medium-skilled workforce.

A manufacturing sector that rewards youth and punishes experience will struggle to retain skilled workers in the decades to come, and erupt in more social friction spilling across both organised and unorganised sectors. Manufacturing-led growth requires a strong domestic consumption base, and one that needs to feel the implicit bargain of industrial employment is being honoured.

The writer is Associate Fellow at the National Council for Applied Economic Research, New Delhi

LETTERS TO EDITOR

Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Voter turnout

This refers to 'The real turnout' (May 1). The record polling figures in recent Assembly elections deserve closer scrutiny. High percentages may suggest vibrant democracy, yet they partly reflect reduced voter rolls after the Special Intensive Revision. True participation must be measured by absolute votes, not percentages alone.

Electoral reforms should ensure that genuine voters are never excluded in the rush to update rolls. Credibility lies not in numbers but in inclusion, transparency, and trust in the process. The focus must shift from statistical triumphs to strengthening voter access and awareness.

Babu Krishna
Bengaluru

The rupee slide

The rupee has fallen significantly, hitting record lows against the US dollar. This depreciation, driven by global and domestic factors, has widespread implications for the economy, including higher import costs and inflationary pressures. Sectors like IT, pharma, textiles, and auto components, which earn in dollars, see higher rupee-denominated profits. NRIs gain more in rupee terms when sending money home, encouraging higher inflows. RBI interventions have managed to curb excess rupee volatility.

CR Krishnan
Ghaziabad, UP

Tech sovereignty

This refers to 'Why India cannot afford to ignore tech sovereignty' (May 1). When critical access depends entirely on the goodwill of a foreign service provider, sovereignty becomes conditional. India's digital infrastructure has grown impressively, but its control over that infrastructure has not kept pace. The proposal for a National Technology Sovereignty Council is worth pursuing seriously. Coordinating disparate efforts under one permanent institution, with defined metrics and accountability, is far more practical than piecemeal responses.

Abbharna Barathi
Chennai

AI and lay-offs

This refers to 'Is AI a mere cover to lay off staff?' (May 1). When AI becomes the stated reason for restructuring that was already planned, it is not transformation — it is convenience with a technology label attached. The disclosure framework proposed here is practical and overdue. Routing AI-related lay-off disclosures through MCA and SEBI, on the same architecture already used for corporate filings, requires no new institution.

Mandatory advisory audits before large workforce reductions would separate genuine AI-driven productivity gains from earnings-call narratives.

Swathi Senthilkumar
Coimbatore

Published by Nirmala Lakshman at No 19&21, Bhagwan Mahaveer Road, Bengaluru-560001 and Printed by C. Sridhar at Plot No. 13-D, Bommasandra-Jigani Link Road, KIADB Industrial Area, Bommasandra, Anekal Taluk, Bengaluru -560099 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., Chennai-600002. Editor: Raghuvir Srinivasan (Editor responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act). ISSN 0971 - 7528

QUICKLY.

Coforge completes Cigniti acquisition post NCLT nod

Hyderabad: Coforge, a Noida-based AI-based engineering services company, has closed the acquisition of the Hyderabad-based Cigniti Technologies. The closure was announced following shareholder approval and final clearance from the National Company Law Tribunal. "Coforge acquired Cigniti to gain access to its tenured relationships, expand its healthcare business and grow its presence in the Midwest and Western regions of the US. The results are now reflected in the data," Coforge said. The company said the acquisition is an example of a firm making a contrarian bet that has worked out and yielded results. OUR BUREAU

Palo Alto Networks to acquire start-up Portkey

Bengaluru: Global cybersecurity company Palo Alto Networks has acquired Elevation Capital-backed AI gateway and observability start-up Portkey. The financial terms of the deal were not disclosed. Portkey equips teams with tools for deploying AI in production, offering an AI gateway, observability, governance and prompt management capabilities. OUR BUREAU

Bombay HC overturns ₹1,524 cr GST demand against Tata Sons

TAX EXEMPTION. Arbitration damages to Docomo are not taxable under GST, says court

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Bombay High Court has set aside a ₹1,524 crore GST demand against Tata Sons, holding that damages paid to Japan's NTT Docomo pursuant to an arbitral award do not constitute a taxable supply under the GST framework.

The dispute arose from a show cause notice and prior tax intimation issued by the Directorate General of GST Intelligence (DGGI), which sought to levy Integrated GST (IGST) on payments made by Tata Sons to Docomo following an international arbitration award.

LEGAL DISTINCTION. The Bench relied on settled legal principles distinguishing compensation for breach of contract from payments made in exchange for a service

LEGAL ENFORCEMENT

The tax authorities argued that the payment amounted to consideration for a "service", specifically for "tolerating an act" or refraining from legal enforcement actions, thereby qualifying as a taxable supply under Schedule II of the Central Goods and Services Tax (CGST) Act. Rejecting this interpretation, the court held that damages awarded in arbitration are compensatory in nature and cannot be equated with consideration for any service.

It observed that the tax department's attempt to classify such payments as a supply stretched the legal definition beyond its intended scope.

The Bench relied on settled legal principles distinguishing compensation for breach of contract from payments made in exchange for a service.

FINDING BUYER

The case traces back to a 2009 shareholders' agreement between Tata Sons and Docomo, under which the Japanese firm invested in Tata Teleservices (TTSL). Under the agreement, it was provided that in the event TTSL failed to meet some performance obligations, it had to find a buyer for Docomo's shares.

It failed to find a buyer and the disputes arose.

The matter went to arbitration at the London Court of International Arbitration, which awarded over $1.17 billion in damages to Docomo.

Tata then deposited an amount of ₹8,450 crore after enforcement proceedings in Indian courts.

Indian IT firms stick to cautious guidance amid weak demand

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Wipro expects a weak start to FY27, guiding for a sequential revenue change of -2 per cent to flat in constant currency (cc) for Q1. Infosys has projected a modest 1.5 per cent to 3.5 per cent year-on-year growth in cc, indicating a gradual recovery, while HCLTech has forecast 1 per cent to 4 per cent revenue growth in cc for the full year.

Providing context to its guidance, HCLTech's MD & CEO C Vijayakumar said in the management commentary that the company saw an impact in March, which was reflected in lower Q4 revenue.

CLIENT SITUATION

"Two large telecom clients cut down discretionary spending for this calendar year. I see this continuing till the end of the year. We are seeing some softness in Europe, while the US is robust except for a specific client situation. For FY27, we see a 0.5 per cent reduction due to two clients — one in manufacturing and the other in retail. We continue to have

a high wallet share, but their business pressures have reduced spending. All of this is driving the overall guidance," he said.

The company's confidence is calibrated, with the lower end of the guidance factoring in continued softness.

It has baked in a 2-3 per cent deflation impact and, barring this, sees 2-5 per cent growth as reasonable in the current uncertain environment. The guidance excludes any acquisitions, which are expected to close during the year and will be called out separately.

Infosys CFO Jayesh Sanghrajka explained during the company's earnings conference call that at the lower end of its guidance, the company has assumed higher deterioration in the environment, and an improved environment at the upper end. "Last year, the company had little clarity about how the environment would change and how tariff changes would impact client behaviour. Today, however, there is better clarity," he said.

From an industry perspective, Sidhant Rastogi, President, Zinnov, noted that guidance is visibly conservative for Indian tier-1 companies.

Infosys guided FY27 growth against a $14.9 billion deal book with 55 per cent net-new. Infosys and HCLTech have an established pattern of under-guiding and delivering at the upper end, typically by 50 to 150 basis points.

"Our base case is that the tier-1 growth cohort — TCS, Infosys, HCL and Tech Mahindra — delivers 3.5 to 5 per cent cc growth in FY27, which is above management midpoints but below the 7 per cent the cohort ran at three years ago. Accenture has already raised its FY26 guidance to 3 to 5 per cent local currency, which is a useful anchor for where the Indian tier-1s will likely exit," he said.

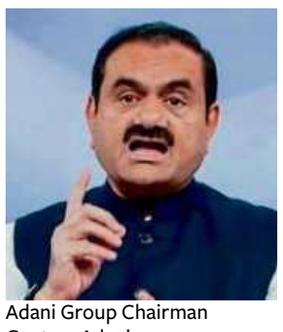
Adani Group eyes homegrown workforce model

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

The Adani Group is looking to build a fully homegrown workforce and eventually phase out lateral hiring, Chairman Gautam Adani said on Friday, while outlining a long-term talent strategy alongside a broader organisational overhaul aimed at speeding up execution.

"I wish for a time — very soon — when lateral hiring at the Adani Group stops completely, and we rely solely on homegrown talent. This is not merely a career path; it is a journey of absolute trust," Adani said in an address on International Labour Day.

The push toward internal talent is also tied to a strong focus on local hiring.



Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani ANI

"We believe that wherever we work, the land, the people and the dreams of that place should grow with us," he said, adding that the group prioritises employment for local communities before looking beyond State or national talent pools.

The shift comes amid a sharp acceleration in the group's growth trajectory.

"Over our first 35 years, we collectively built assets worth approximately ₹2 lakh crore. And today, such is our standing that within this single year alone, we are going to add another ₹2 lakh crore in new assets," he said.

To support this expansion, the group is rolling out three structural changes, starting with a "three-layer model" aimed at flattening hierarchies and accelerating decision-making.

"As organisations grow larger, decisions become slower, and things take longer to move from one level to another. We don't want this to happen," Adani said.

"We want decisions that currently take three days to be made at a site to be made in just three hours."

He added that a leaner structure would also open up opportunities for younger employees. "When layers are reduced, decisions are made faster, work speed increases, and the entire organisation is filled with new energy."

STREAMLINING OPS

The second pillar of the overhaul is a partnership-led execution model, which seeks to streamline operations across project sites.

"Today, at many of our sites, more than 100 contractors are working simultaneously. Coordinating with many people requires a distinct organisational framework," Adani said.

The group now plans to work with a smaller set of trusted partners, who can take end-to-end responsibility for projects, improving speed and accountability.

The third pillar focuses on learning and development, with an emphasis on continuous skill-building and clear career progression. "If someone is unskilled, they should become semi-skilled; from semi-skilled, they should progress to being skilled; and eventually, they should rise to become a supervisor, manager or leader," he added.

'Hiring activity up 6 per cent in April'

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

India's white-collar hiring grew by 6 per cent year-on-year in April this fiscal, mainly driven by the insurance, BPO/ITeS and real estate sectors, according to a report released on Friday.

Insurance led the sectoral hiring by registering 21 per cent y-o-y growth, followed by BPO/ITES (15 per cent), real estate (12 per cent), healthcare (11 per cent) and education (9 per cent), according to the *Naukri JobSpeak Index* report. However, telecom and banking sectors continued their four-month decline, falling to 11 per cent and 10 per cent respectively in April, while IT, pharma and auto remained largely flat, the report said.

Even hiring in the global capability centres (GCC) witnessed a 4 per cent dip in April, it added.

SOUTHERN CITIES RISE

When it came to geographies, among the top metros, southern cities dominated the trajectory, with Hyderabad recording 12 per cent growth, followed by Bengaluru (7 per cent) and Chennai (6 per cent).

Delhi-NCR (at 3 per cent) saw modest single-digit growth, Kolkata remained largely flat (1 per cent), and Mumbai was the only major metro in negative territory at 3 per cent, according to the report. Beyond the metros, the report found that emerging cities like Jaipur (12 per cent), Coimbatore (11 per cent) and Ahmedabad (7 per cent) continued to post firm growth, underlining the spread of hiring demand into tier-2 markets.

'CFO role in entertainment sector has moved from financial oversight to strategic leadership'

bl.interview

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

After a year as the Chief Financial Officer at Nielsen, Jessica Holscott talks about the evolution of a CFO's job description in the media and entertainment industry. Having worked on the other side of the business, with giants such as Warner Media, Holscott puts the ad measurement segment into perspective and talks about how the company plans to reinvest in its products and solutions with India serving as the initial testing ground for innovation.

Edited excerpts:

> There's a good chance that we continue to increase the workforce in India. I'm incredibly impressed with the talent pool here, just on the velocity of work that happens in India
>
> **JESSICA HOLSCOTT**
> Chief Financial Officer, Nielsen

Has the CFO job moved beyond earnings numbers?

It has definitely shifted from more financial oversight to strategic leadership. "How do we drive capital allocation towards innovation and growth to drive topline? Are we investing in the right products?" Evaluating ROI across fragmented media channels, partnering with the Board on long-term strategy, those are things I focus on every day.

You came here after a short stint at Spotter and Warner Media before that. How has the experience been?

I'm blessed to have spent much of my career on the other side. I had the linear networks and I was a part of the HBO Max streaming platform launch. I understood the product workflows, which has been incredibly important while coming to Nielsen. I understood the customer workflows and how Nielsen's products can solve some of the questions we were facing at Warner Media. For me, coming to Nielsen has been a a full circle moment. What it allowed me to do as a CFO is to ensure that there's a product market for us.

Nielsen is into private ownership under Elliot and Brookfield. How has the shift away from quarterly public reporting changed your capital allocation strategy?

Under private ownership, we've really transformed the business with key talent here in India — whether that's in technology, product development or the finance team. This has allowed us to generate cash to reinvest back into the company, growth products that create future growth for Nielsen around streaming, ad products. Elliot and Brookfield have been incredibly supportive of investing in our products.

For Nielsen's global strategy, what role does India play?

India is a key growth market for us. It is a strategic hub for engineering, data science, and analytics and finance. Given the nature of the media ecosystem, it's becoming increasingly clear that we use this as a 'test-and-learn' country. If we can make it work here from a market fit standpoint, we can make it work in many other countries, given the complexity here.

Are you thinking of expanding workforce in India?

Very much so ... as we continue to evolve our product suite because this is where we are seeing the strength from a talent pool standpoint. There's a good chance that we continue to increase the workforce in India. I'm incredibly impressed with the talent pool here, just on the velocity of work that happens in India. The talent pool here is world class.

Debt servicing is a significant line item, especially after the $16 billion buyout. With the interest rates remaining a focal point in 2026, what's your current strategy for managing the company's leverage?

We paid down debt, which has been a priority for us. We also refined our debt last year. We issued $1.2 billion notes in November 2025 and another $1.5 billion in January 2027. We also refinanced term loan B's together, about $4.6 billion... altogether, over $7 billion of debt refinanced in just the last half year. That generates interest savings for refinancing to reinvest back into ad products, streaming solutions and Gracenote.

What sustains your confidence in terms of staying competitive in the current market?

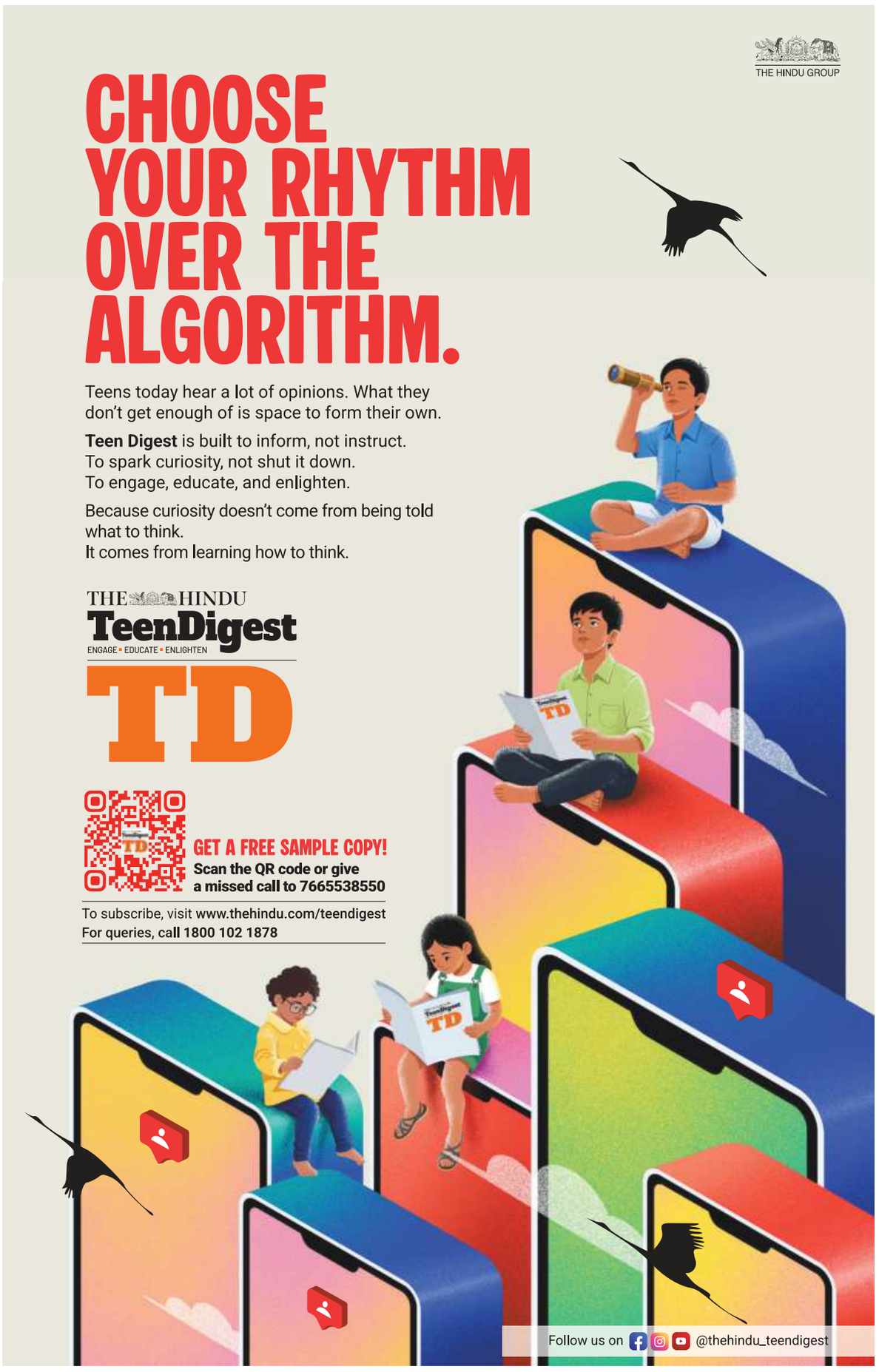
We have products that measure linear, streaming and both. Streaming-plus gives us the next leg of that journey, which is tracking apps viewing behaviour across mobile and connected TV. The CTV audience base grew 85 per cent last year, and Gracenote provides the rich metadata for content discovery. Everything we do is in service of that evolving media landscape.

Where will Nielsen's next phase of growth come from? Is it core measurement or adjacent businesses like data and analytics, and content discovery?

It's going to come from a variety of areas. Streaming is going to be a massive growth driver for us. Sports, creators are another growth factor. From a product standpoint: the advertising products, the content discovery engine. As that content grows, it needs to be measured. AI will obviously be a component of all of this.

Any top three goals for the year going forward?

We will continue to invest towards being the leader in cross-platform audience measurement and digital ad effectiveness and content insights, tailored to meet the needs of Indian marketers and broadcasters.



BENGALURU
businessline.
SATURDAY - MAY 2 - 2026

QUICKLY.

Gold heads for weekly loss on inflation worries

Gold prices fell more than 1 per cent on Friday and were headed for a weekly loss of a similar magnitude as elevated oil prices continued to fan inflation concerns. Spot gold was down 1.1 per cent at $4,573.33 per ounce at 1149 GMT, and on track for a weekly loss of 2.8 per cent. US gold futures for June delivery fell 1 per cent to $4,585.20. Silver prices fell 0.3 per cent to $73.53 per ounce. REUTERS

Crude oil up with no sign of Iran conflict ending

Crude oil rose on Friday as efforts to resolve the Iran conflict have hit an impasse, with Tehran still blocking the Strait of Hormuz and the US Navy blocking exports of Iranian crude. Brent crude futures for July rose $1.19 to $111.59 a barrel by 0149 GMT, while US WTI futures were up 39 cents to $105.46. REUTERS

Aluminium rebounds on supply concerns

London: Aluminium prices bounced back on fears of supply shortages as the stand-off between the US and Iran continued, constricting shipments from the Gulf region. Benchmark three-month aluminium on the LME rose 1.4 per cent to $3,522 a tonne. Copper dipped 0.2 per cent to $12,965. REUTERS

El Nino may last until January 2027, could impact kharif and rabi crops

IMD OUTLOOK. S-W monsoon may set in over Andamans around May 14-16; average rainfall during May to be above normal

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Friday said that most global models forecast the emergence of El Nino during the monsoon season and it may last at least until January 2027, potentially bringing lower rain both during the kharif and rabi seasons.

The IMD also said that the monsoon may hit the Andaman and Nicobar Islands around May 14-16.

Currently, El Nino Southern Oscillation (ENSO)-neutral conditions over the equatorial Pacific are evolving towards El Nino, which may continue till January 2027. Though positive Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) conditions help monsoon rain, the impact of El Nino could overshadow even if the IOD becomes near-positive, said Mrutyunjay Mohapatra, Director General of the IMD.

At present, neutral IOD conditions are prevailing over the Indian Ocean, and the latest climate models indicate that positive IOD conditions are likely to develop towards the end of the monsoon season.

The kharif sowing season begins with the onset of monsoon on the mainland around June 1, while rabi (winter) crops planting commences in October.

LOWER RAINFALL

The IMD has already predicted below normal monsoon, quantitatively 92 per cent of the long period average of 87 cm in 2026. Last year, the South-West monsoon hit the Kerala coast on May 24, the earliest since 2009 from the normal date of June 1. The onset over the Andaman and Nicobar Islands was also a week earlier on May 13, against the normal May 20.

Briefing the media on the IMD's monthly weather forecast during May, Mohapatra said above-normal heatwave days are likely in some parts of the foothills of the Himalayas, East Coast States, Gujarat and Maharashtra. He said the average rainfall over the country as a whole during May is most likely to be above normal.

PARCHED. The IMD has predicted above-normal heatwave days in some parts of the foothills of the Himalayas, East Coast States, Gujarat and Maharashtra in May

"During May, minimum (night) temperatures are expected to be above normal across many parts of the country. However, many areas of North-West and some parts of Central India and adjoining areas of south peninsular region are likely to experience normal to below-normal minimum temperatures," he said.

Also, some parts of East, North-East and East Central India may witness below-normal rainfall whereas it is expected to be above normal over the remaining parts of India.

Kalyan Goswami, Director General of the Agrochem Federation of India (ACFI), said that good rainfall this month may help boost kharif sowing by ensuring adequate soil moisture. Farmers growing paddy, pulses and oilseeds may get a boost to start sowing on time, potentially raising rural disposable incomes, he said.

Ankur Aggarwal, Chairman, CropLife India, said the kharif season this year is being shaped by two parallel risks. On one side, the monsoon is projected at 92 per cent of the long-period average due to El Nino emerging. It could lead to delayed sowing, uneven crop establishment and heightened pest and disease pressure.

Dry spells followed by intermittent humidity could create favourable conditions for outbreaks such as blast and sheath blight in rice, fall armyworm and stalk rot in maize, sucking pests in cotton and charcoal rot in soybean.

At the same time, the West Asia conflict had led to supply chain disruptions of key inputs like methanol, ammonia, LPG and petrochemical derivatives.

This is translating into higher costs and potential tightness, even as recent government measures, including customs duty exemptions, aim to ease availability.

Wheat procurement down 9% on lower buy in Madhya Pradesh

Intake falls

Wheat procurement (lakh tonnes)*

	2025	2026	% change
Madhya Pradesh	67.58	27.49	-59.3
Rajasthan	11.44	9.76	-14.7
Uttar Pradesh	7.55	7.12	-5.7
Haryana	65.67	76.58	16.6
Punjab	103.8	111.02	7
Bihar^	14,291	19,485	36.3
All India	256.31	232.53	-9.3

^in tonne, *Until April 30 Source: CFPP Portal

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The Union government procured 23.25 million tonnes (mt) of wheat for its buffer stocks as of April 30, down from 25.63 mt a year ago. This was mainly due to purchases in Madhya Pradesh being low. It procured 2.75 mt, down 59 per cent from 6.768 mt a year ago, despite improvement in procurement during the second fortnight. The Centre plans to buy 34.5 mt of wheat by June 30 this year.

However, with daily arrivals falling in Haryana and Punjab, procurement may be completed before May 15, with 97 per cent of the target achieved. Daily arrivals on April 30 were 3.38 lakh tonnes (lt) against 4.07 lt a year ago in Punjab and about 25,900 tonnes against over 46,000 tonnes in Haryana.

According to the latest data, procurement in Punjab reached 11.10 mt (including about 10.5 mt only in the second fortnight) against 10.39 mt a year ago, up by 7 per cent. The Centre has fixed a target to procure 11.2 mt from Punjab in 2026-27, against 11.92 mt in 2025-26.

Notably, the current year's purchase also includes 1.81 lt of grain under relaxed quality even as there were reports of widespread lustre loss in several districts due to unseasonal rain and hailstorms in Punjab.

HARYANA TARGET

In Haryana, the Centre has purchased 7.66 mt, exceeding the target of 7.2 mt, and is up by 17 per cent from 6.57 mt a year ago. In 2025-26, the Centre bought 7.14 mt of wheat from Haryana.

The purchase in Madhya Pradesh continued to trail from the year-ago level despite improvement in the second fortnight. The fall was 91 per cent in the first 15 days despite purchases being allowed from March 15 instead of April 1. The drop has narrowed to 13 per cent over the past 15 days.

Even with lower purchase, the Centre raised the overall target in the State from 7.8 mt to 10 mt. In 2025-26, the Centre procured 7.77 mt from Madhya Pradesh. Besides, the State government has been implementing additional bonus over and above the minimum support price (MSP) of ₹2,585 per quintal.

The purchase in Uttar Pradesh reached 7.12 lt against 7.54 lt and in Rajasthan 9.76 lt from 11.44 lt. In Bihar, the procurement reached 19,485 tonnes, up 36 per cent from 14,291 tonnes a year ago.

The government last week raised the purchase target in Uttar Pradesh from 1 mt to 2.5 mt, in Rajasthan from 2.1 mt to 2.35 mt and in Bihar from 0.18 lt to 1.8 lt.

Storage in over 50% of reservoirs below 40% of capacity

Our Bureau
Chennai

Storage in over 50 per cent of India's 166 major reservoirs dropped below 40 per cent of their capacity last week, even as the overall level fell below 40 per cent of capacity, data from the Central Water Commission (CWC) showed.

The CWC's weekly status on the major reservoirs showed that the level in the southern region dropped below 30 per cent.

The level in the 166 reservoirs was 38.72 per cent of the 183.565 billion cubic metres (BCM) capacity at 71.082 BCM, with storage in the remaining four above 40 per cent. Storage was, however, higher by 14 percentage points a year ago and 26.5 percentage points than normal (past 10 years).

BENGAL PRECARIOUS

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), over a third of the country received deficient or no rainfall from March 1 to April 29.

However, pre-monsoon rainfall has begun to lash some parts of the country, particularly the South. Storage in the southern region's 47 reservoirs was 28 per cent of the 55.288 BCM capacity at 15.580 BCM. The level in Telangana was the lowest at 20.87 per cent, while it was 24 per cent in Karnataka. Andhra Pradesh had the highest storage at 39 per cent, while it was 37 per cent in Tamil Nadu, and 28 per cent in Kerala.

With the level in Bengal declining to 12 per cent and in Assam to 18.5 per cent, the 27 reservoirs in the eastern region were filled to 34 per cent or 7.481 BCM of the 21.759 BCM capacity.

MORE DECLINE LIKELY

Storage in 11 reservoirs in the northern region was 43 per cent of the 19.836 BCM capacity at 8.593 BCM.

Storage in the 53 reservoirs of the western region was 45 per cent of the 38.094 BCM capacity at 17.187 BCM.

The 28 reservoirs in the central legion were filled to 45.7 per cent or 22.241 BCM of the 48.588 BCM capacity.

With summer at its peak and heatwaves reported across various parts of the country, storage will likely decline further.

UAE's exit from OPEC could benefit India in the long term

bl.explainer

Richa Mishra
Hyderabad

Remember the famous song by Queen, "*I Want to Break Free*"... Well, it seems that is what the United Arab Emirates (UAE) wanted to do from OPEC and OPEC plus, while singing, "*I don't need you; I've got to break free!*"

Effective May 1, 2026, the UAE has freed itself from the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) — a permanent inter-governmental organisation — with a primary mission to coordinate and unify petroleum policies among member countries to ensure stable oil prices and a regular supply to consuming nations.

For the UAE, experts and commentators see this move as a strategic shift to prioritise national interests and monetise its massive production capacity, which was previously constrained by cartel quotas.

But what does it mean for India?

CARTEL RECAST. Effective May 1, the UAE exited the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries, the intergovernmental group that coordinates member nations' oil policies to stabilise prices and ensure steady global supply

How does it affect India's energy security?

Currently, the UAE is among the top five crude oil suppliers for India. In the long term, the exit from OPEC means that it can offer higher volumes and have more flexible supply arrangements without any restrictions.

On its part, India has been looking at diversifying its crude sourcing basket. This gives Indian refiners an opportunity to negotiate and get volumes in a competitive supply environment.

India can also strengthen its bilateral energy partnerships and look at more collaboration for its Strategic Petroleum Reserves, besides growing cooperation with ADNOC.

Will oil prices in India go down?

While the fluctuations in international prices do have an impact on the Indian crude oil basket or the price at which Indian refiners source their oil, at the retail end pricing is largely governed by politics.

According to reports, analysts expect downward pressure on global prices as the UAE aims to ramp up capacity to 5 million barrels per day (bpd) by 2027.

Every $1-per-barrel drop in oil prices is estimated to save India approximately $1.1 billion to $2 billion annually in import costs, analysts estimate.

What are the logistical advantages?

There is a logistical advantage due to the geographical proximity between India and the UAE.

The UAE is significantly closer to India than the other major oil exporters, such as the US or Brazil, leading to lower freight costs and shorter delivery cycles.

The UAE's Fujairah Port on the Gulf of Oman allows some crude to bypass the troubled Strait of Hormuz, providing a more secure transit route during regional conflicts.

Will it supplement rupee trade in oil?

Time and again, debate has happened on de-dollarisation of the oil trade. It is a strategic global shift, where nations move away from using the dollar as the primary currency for energy transactions.

This trend has gained significant momentum, driven by geo-political risks and the desire for currency stability.

Trading in local currencies helps India reduce its reliance on the dollar, potentially stabilising the rupee and lowering exchange rate risks, experts point out.

An independent UAE energy policy is expected to accelerate the oil-for-rupee trade.

Observers believe that UAE's exit from OPEC will be a game changer for de-dollarisation.

By operating outside the cartel's dollar-pegged framework, the UAE has more freedom to negotiate direct, bilateral trade deals in non-dollar currencies.

India and the UAE have already established mechanisms to trade oil in Indian Rupees and AED (United Arab Emirates Dirham).

This eliminates the need for a third-party currency and protects India from US dollar volatility.

Agrizy opens botanicals lab for wellness markets

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Agrizy, a contract research, development and manufacturing organisation (CRDMO) for global food and beverage (F&B) as well as wellness brands, has announced the launch of its phytochemistry R&D laboratory.

The facility is designed to produce high-performance botanical ingredients while improving the value flow across India's herbal supply chain, from farm to finished product, the company said in a statement.

GLOBAL STANDARDS

Strategically positioned to cater to the $650 billion global nutraceutical market, including India, the facility aims to meet the growing demand for scientifically validated and regulatory-compliant botanical ingredients.

Although India has a strong advantage in raw materials, its competitiveness in this evolving market relies on scientific validation, standardisation and regulatory compliance.

"This investment enhances our capability to develop scientifically validated herbal ingredients that comply with global standards and deliver consistent performance. By combining traditional botanical knowledge with advanced research, extraction technologies and strong quality systems, we are creating standardised ingredients that meet international expectations," said S Vijaya Kumar, CEO, Wellness, Agrizy. It collaborates with farmers and FPOs and village level aggregators across Karnataka, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu and Bengal, key regions known for botanicals such as turmeric, coleus, bacopa and ashwagandha.

Coconut oil, copra slump amid weak demand, export disruptions

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

A surge in production and export disruptions following the West Asia crisis have dented coconut oil and copra prices.

Thalath Mahmood, President of the Cochin Oil Merchants Association (COMA), said coconut oil prices in Kerala had dropped to ₹266 per litre, while copra rates came down to ₹153.

This is a sharp decline from last July's peak of ₹393 and ₹259 for coconut oil and copra, respectively.

Raw coconut prices have also decreased significantly, falling about ₹36 per kg over the past seven months.

MUTED DEMAND

He said that the demand was subdued both at the corporate level and in local purchases, and the declining price trend is likely to continue unless the supply reduces with the onset of the monsoon.

There are also reports of stocks being liquidated by traders in Tamil Nadu in view of the price fall.

HIGHER OUTPUT

P Vinod Kumar of the Coconut Producer Consortium, Palakkad, said higher production also played a major role in the price drop as increased output of fresh coconuts across producing States had led to excess supply in the market. Another factor is the shift in consumer preference.

WAR, OTHER FACTORS

Industry sources pointed out that the West Asia conflict had disrupted exports of coconut products to the Gulf markets.

This, coupled with labour exodus to West Bengal and Assam for the Assembly elections hit copra processing, leading to reduced procurement of fresh nuts and contributing to a price fall.

Sunny George of the Tejaswini Coconut Producer Company said that raw nut prices in Kannur had dropped to ₹45 per kg in the wholesale market due to increased production.

The prices were at their peak at around ₹70-75 earlier. He pointed out that the prices might decline further if the supply continues to rise.

Supply-side risks may support zinc; trade may remain volatile

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Zinc prices, which have dropped over 2.5 per cent in the past week, will likely be supported by supply-side risks, though the trade could remain volatile, analysts have said.

"Zinc prices are expected to remain supported by supply side risks, even as zinc consumption growth slows to 1.9 per cent in 2026 from 2.2 per cent in 2025," said research agency BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions.

The recent sharp decline was the result of a confluence of four bearish factors — a demand vacuum, profit-booking, a surplus of refined material in February and the retreat of macro-economic risk appetite, said SurnSirs Commodity data group.

PRICE FORECAST

"We are revising our 2026 zinc price forecast to $2,950/tonne from $2,780 previously, with prices set to remain underpinned by persistent input-cost pressures," said BMI.

Zinc prices averaged $3,277/tonne year-to-date as of April 17 and are up 8 per cent year-on-year, extending the 2025 momentum, when prices averaged $2,867, supported by sizeable stock withdrawals and growing expectations of tighter supply.

In its *Commodity Outlook*, the World Bank said global zinc production is expected to increase modestly in 2026, with rising mine output in major producing countries improving concentrate availability, but elevated energy costs tempering the expansion of refined output.

"Against this backdrop, prices are forecast to increase by about 5 per cent in 2026," it said.

POOR OFFTAKE. However, zinc consumption may slow down to 1.9 per cent this year, said BMI

IRAN WAR DISRUPTIONS

Zinc prices increased in the first quarter this year by 2 per cent compared with the last quarter of 2025 and extended gains in April. This was due to disruptions to zinc concentrate supplies linked to the conflict in West Asia, and weaker deliveries from other sources hindering Chinese smelting output, the World Bank said.

BMI said zinc prices experienced volatility in the first quarter, with early-year gains driven by supply-side concerns later offset by macro-led uncertainty following the escalation of the US-Iran conflict in late February.

In recent weeks, prices have rebounded as the conflict intensified concerns around the availability of key inputs, exacerbating existing pressures on smelters, it said.

The World Bank said continued weakness in China's property sector is expected to weigh on steel consumption and galvanizing activity, dampening zinc demand in 2026-27.

"Rising zinc consumption related to growing global investment in infrastructure, power grids and renewable energy installations is likely to provide some offset, resulting in modest global demand growth overall," it said.

BMI said the Iran war had compounded pre-existing tightness in the sulphur market. It had exacerbated input-cost risks for smelters and emerged as a key driver of prices.

QUICKLY.

Repolling in 15 booths in West Bengal today: EC

New Delhi: The Election Commission on Friday ordered repolling on May 2 in 15 polling stations — 11 in the Magarhat Paschim Assembly constituency and four in Diamond Harbour — in West Bengal, where voting was held on April 29. In a letter to the Chief Electoral Officer of West Bengal, the Election Commission (EC) said the decision was based on inputs received from the State poll machinery. PTI

Power consumption up 4% to 154 BU in April

New Delhi: Power consumption in the country witnessed 4 per cent growth to 153.99 billion units (BU) in April compared to the year-ago period as unseasonal rain subdued power demand, especially in the first half of the month, according to official data. The country's total power consumption was 148 BU in April 2025. However, power demand rose in the latter part of the month due to heatwave conditions, and the peak power demand jumped to a record high of 256.11 GW last month from 235.32 GW in April 2025. Peak power demand may hit 270 GW in the summer of 2026, the Ministry said. PTI

BIS formalises safety norms for mobility aids

New Delhi: The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) has published six new standards for assistive products, ranging from elbow crutches to portable wheelchair ramps, as the country moves to align its disability-aid industry with international benchmarks. The standards were developed under the Indian Council of Medical Research's National List of Essential Assistive Products initiative, the Consumer Affairs Ministry said. PTI

India, UK exploring ways to leverage CETA to boost trade

TAPPING POTENTIAL. Discussed ways to further enhance the benefits of ties, says Goyal

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and UK Secretary of State for Business and Trade Peter Kyle discussed boosting trade under the India-UK free trade pact in a virtual meeting on Friday as the two sides prepare to implement the agreement.

"We explored ways to further enhance our trade & investment ties while fully leveraging the opportunities under the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA)," Goyal posted on social media platform 'X' after the interaction.

India and the UK signed the CETA in July 2025, and Goyal earlier indicated that it was likely to be implemented by May.

The implementation will happen once all domestic processes for ratification are complete, officials said.

Once implemented, the UK will eliminate tariffs for India on about 99 per cent of tariff lines. Agriculture, food processing, seafood, textiles, engineering goods, electronics, footwear and gems & jewellery are among the sectors that will benefit most.

A file photo of Union Minister Piyush Goyal with UK Secretary of State for Business and Trade Peter Kyle ANI

TARIFF-FREE ACCESS

India agreed to give tariff-free access to the UK on 85 per cent of its tariff lines spread over 10 years, resulting in significant gains for whisky and liquor, automobiles, advanced manufacturing and agri-food products.

India also hopes to make gains in the services sector as the agreement provides deeper market access across IT, financial services, education and healthcare.

It also creates a structured framework for the temporary movement of professionals. Business visitors, contractual service suppliers and independent professionals can now access the UK under clear and predictable entry rules.

Up to 1,800 Indian chefs, yoga instructors and classical musicians can work in the UK every year under these provisions.

BIG SAVINGS

The Double Contribution Convention (DCC), which exempts Indian workers and their employers from paying UK social security contributions for up to three years when on temporary assignments, is expected to lead to big savings.

"Around 75,000 workers and over 900 companies are expected to benefit, resulting in savings of more than ₹4,000 crore," per government estimates.

India, UAE trade exceeds $100 b after pact: Goyal

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The India-UAE free trade agreement, which came into force in May 2022, has helped bilateral trade to cross $100 billion, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Friday.

The Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) with the UAE acts as a gateway to Africa, other GCCs and West Asia, the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) countries and Europe.

The bilateral trade stood at $101.25 billion in 2025-26, compared to $100.03 billion in 2024-25.

The trade, he said, had expanded in key sectors like gems and jewellery, engineering goods, electronics and agriculture.

During 2025-26, India's exports to the UAE rose about 2 per cent to $37.36 billion, while imports were up 0.77 per cent to $63.89 billion, resulting in a trade deficit of $26.53 billion.

FDI from the UAE into India stood at $2.45 billion during April-December FY26. It was $4.34 billion in 2024-25.

GIFT City's watering holes scale new highs

Revenues earned (in ₹)

FY	Hotel Grand Mercure	GIFT City Club	Total
2023-24*	41,750	78,432	1,20,182
2024-25	13,26,855	18,01,115	31,27,970
2025-26	46,56,119	1,48,13,621	1,94,69,740

*December to March

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

A quiet policy shift in India's most tightly regulated alcohol market is beginning to show up in the numbers. At GIFT City, revenues from "wine and dine" facilities have seen significant traction following a gradual easing of liquor access norms.

The impact is now becoming visible in absolute terms. Revenues from these facilities rose to ₹1.94 crore in FY26 from ₹31.27 lakh in FY25, even as the State continues to enforce prohibition elsewhere.

SPREADING CHEER

While the revenue base remains modest, the sharp rise underscores how demand responds quickly when access barriers are lowered, even within a tightly controlled ecosystem.

This growth comes barely a year after controlled liquor access was first allowed in the greenfield financial hub in December 2023.

Liquor sales in GIFT City are currently restricted to just two entities — the Grand Mercure Gandhinagar GIFT City and GIFT City Club, operated by West India Recreation Projects Pvt Ltd.

Revenue at Grand Mercure rose 3.5 times year-on-year, while the GIFT City Club saw an eight-fold jump, indicating strong latent demand. Officials attribute the surge to a calibrated easing of prohibition norms by the Gujarat government.

EASING ACCESS

The revised framework allows non-resident visitors to access liquor by simply producing a valid photo ID, removing the earlier requirement of obtaining a liquor permit.

Permit holders can now host up to 25 guests at a time, while diners without permits are allowed entry into wine-and-dine areas for food. Employees working in GIFT City are also eligible to obtain liquor access permits based on their ID cards, further widening the pool of eligible consumers within the restricted zone.

Since 2024, a total of 1,320 liquor permits, including six group permits, have been issued in GIFT City.

The State government earned about ₹26.5 lakh from permit fees so far. Individual permits are priced at ₹2,000 with a validity of two years, while group permits cost ₹5,000. According to industry sources, the GIFT City model is increasingly being seen as a limited but significant experiment in relaxing prohibition norms to support a global business environment, without diluting the broader policy framework in Gujarat.

Himadri Speciality plans to double profitability

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Himadri Speciality Chemical has announced a roadmap to more than double its profitability by FY28.

The company expects to cash in on the investments made in the last few years by catapulting its revenue and profitability, said the company in its annual report.

"Growth at Himadri continues to be shaped by purposeful innovation, with R&D embedded at the core of strategy, business model and culture. This integrated approach is driving steady progress across strategic pillars," said Anurag Choudhary, Chairman and CEO, Himadri Speciality.

In FY'27, the company will achieve a full year of operations of the capacity expansion in speciality carbon black.

TYRE OUTPUT TO GROW

Himadri also intends to ramp up the capacity of Birla Tyres and enter the high margin off highway tyres (OHT) and commercial vehicle segment.

Anurag Choudhary, Chairman and CEO, Himadri Speciality

DOWNSTREAM CHEM

In its core chemicals business, Himadri Speciality Chemical is planning forward integration to produce anthraquinone and carbazone, which it expects to be completed by the second quarter of this financial year.

"The commencement of the facility is on track in the coming quarters and will meaningfully reduce India's dependence on imports across dyes and pigments," Choudhary added.

The company expects the first phase of the commercial plant for lithium iron phosphate (LFP) cathode active material to be operational by the third quarter of FY27 and has plans to ramp up its Durofresh brand of naphthalene balls. The company also expects higher revenues to flow in from the LFP cathode active material plant and full operations to be achieved for the naphthalene balls business, it added.

GCCs provide stable income visibility for longer tenures: Mindspace REIT CEO

bl.interview

Janaki Krishnan
Mumbai

Ramesh Nair, CEO, Mindspace Business Parks REIT, struck a confident note on the outlook for office demand, highlighting that global capability centres (GCCs), which account for over 50 per cent of the portfolio, are driving resilient, high-quality leasing with long tenures and lower cyclicality. "GCCs are willing to give us longer tenures, which means there is more stability of income for us," Nair said.

Edited excerpts:

GCCs form around half of your leasing portfolio. Can you give more colour on this trend?

So, the first point is 50 per cent of our portfolio comprises GCCs, 20 per cent IT services and 30 per cent large Indian domestic organisations. GCC demand is spread across sectors such as technology, BFSI, manufacturing and engineering.

India currently has around 2,900 GCCs, which we expect to grow to about 4,400 by 2030. Employment in this segment is projected to increase from 1.9 million to 2.8 million, and the industry size from $65 billion to about $105 billion.

Three things we have seen with GCC clientele — they are a lot stickier to their locations, they employ a significant amount of higher skill talent, and they have a lot less cyclicality compared to IT services.

GCCs are also willing to give us longer tenures, which means there is more stability of income for us.

Typically, GCCs do not have a problem signing 10-plus year leases, with longer lock-ins.

In terms of pricing, is there any pushback from large global occupiers, and what is the trend in rentals ?

Exactly the opposite. In my 26 years in the industry, I have not seen this kind of rental growth as in the last two years. Let us not go by one-month data.

Now, construction costs, for example, have gone up 6.5 per cent since January, but you should also remember that we do not buy all the paint right now, we do not buy all the cement today.

We buy cement over a period of three years, we buy aluminium over a period of 2.5 years, so in that time we can spread out the costs.

Are you seeing any slowdown at all ?

We have not experienced any slowdown ourselves. However, we are hearing from the market that in some cases decision-making has slowed. This could be due to limited international travel and some caution around capex. During periods of global uncertainty, historically, companies tend to slow down capex.

> GCCs are a lot stickier to their locations, employ a significant amount of higher skill talent, and they have a lot less cyclicality compared to IT services
>
> **RAMESH NAIR**
> CEO, Mindspace Business Parks REIT

Your re-leasing spreads were about 40 per cent this quarter. Is that sustainable over the next couple of years?

A 40 per cent spread is strong, but for the next couple of years, a more sustainable number would be around 20 per cent.

Returning to rentals, how much of this rental upside is cyclical versus structural?

Demand is currently exceeding supply in most markets. Hyderabad is a great example — vacancy in key micro-markets like Madhapur is around 2 per cent. In Mumbai's BKC, vacancy is below 1 per cent. Another important factor is industry consolidation.

While there are about 14,000 developers in India, only 15-16 have a multi-city office development strategy. We are among that group, which gives us a competitive advantage.

So, both cyclical supply constraints and structural factors like asset quality are driving rental growth.

Is your high exposure to Hyderabad a risk?

Not at all. In fact, it is benefiting us. Hyderabad is a very strong market today, with about 46 per cent of new GCCs setting up there. It is seeing over 25 per cent rental growth, supported by strong infrastructure, talent availability and social infrastructure. Today, we are benefiting so much from this 40 per cent in Hyderabad.

Your presence in Chennai has increased. What is the strategy there?

When we evaluated which market to enter for acquisitions, Chennai came out on top. The vacancy in Chennai is around 7 per cent, compared to the national average of 15 per cent. In terms of upcoming institutional supply, Chennai again ranked the highest, given the relatively limited supply pipeline.

That is why we chose to acquire two assets there — where we can effectively control supply and build a strong market position. With these acquisitions, we become the second-largest owner/developer of office space in Chennai.

There are a few key aspects to these assets. Both were acquired from institutional players — K Raheja Corp and CapitaLand. They are premium, high-quality assets with strong sustainability credentials and low carbon footprints. They are also trophy business parks with clear mark-to-market potential; we have the ability to release them at higher rentals going forward.

Concorde leases 1.4 lakh sq ft office space at Econex Bengaluru

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Bengaluru-based Concorde has leased 1.4 lakh sq ft of grade-A office space at Concorde Econex at an annual rental value of ₹16 crore from BHIVE Workspaces.

The facility is located in the prominent tech corridor of Doddanekkundi in Bengaluru; the partnership is structured as a long-term commitment, with a 15-year lease that will enable BHIVE to add over 3,000 seats in the city.

The deal underscores the continued boom in east Bengaluru, particularly in areas such as Whitefield, Marathahalli and the Outer Ring Road corridor, which are home to some of India's largest information technology parks and multinational companies, which include Bagmane Tech Park and Google's Ananta campus.

On the residential front, east Bengaluru continues to hold the highest share of unsold housing stock at 43 per cent, followed by north Bengaluru at 32 per cent, according to Anarock.

In terms of budget segmentation, high-end units account for the largest share of available inventory at 38 per cent, followed by luxury housing at 31 per cent and mid-segment homes at 19 per cent. Ultra-luxury residences make up 8 per cent of the stock, while the affordable segment accounts for a modest 5 per cent.

High-level panel to enable banks leverage their capital: DFS Secretary

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Financial Services Secretary M Nagaraju on Friday said the High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat announced in this year's Budget will look into public sector bank balance sheet constraints to enable them to leverage their capital.

The government is expected to announce the terms of reference for the panel.

"This committee is expected to review the banking sector with a focus on making it more effective, more inclusive and better aligned with India's growth needs, while maintaining financial stability," he said at the ICPP Growth Conference here.

ACCESS TO CAPITAL

On the deepening bond market, Nagaraju said India needs to develop its corporate bond market so that companies that are not top rated also get access to capital.

"In India, 90-95 per cent of bond issuances are from companies that are AA or above rated. In US, the bulk of the market is A and BBB rated. The middle tier of bond market doesn't exist." Therefore, he said, companies face difficulty in raising funds in long-duration tenors, and long-term capital borrowers must tap the corporate bond market for funds. "The ability of long-term institutional investors to participate more actively in the corporate bond market will be an important factor in determining how deep and liquid that market can become," he said.

Financial sector regulators, the government and the high-level committee on banking will have to consider the interlinkages with the banking sector at large.

Nagaraju stressed that a well-functioning bond market gives companies a direct route to long-term capital, improves price discovery and creates competition that keeps borrower costs honest across the system.

"If capital reaches only the most credit-worthy borrowers, the financial system is doing its job at a basic level. If it also reaches those who are viable, but currently underserved, the system is working efficiently," Nagaraju said.

"The question is whether capital is affordable for the farmer, the small business that wants to expand or the infrastructure project that needs long-term financing," he said.

Mysore Sandal soap maker to set up ₹228 cr production unit

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The Karnataka Cabinet has approved the proposal to establish a production unit of the State-owned Karnataka Soaps and Detergents Ltd (KSDL) in Vijayapura at a cost of ₹227.91 crore.

Large and Medium Industries and District In-charge Minister MB Patil said KSDL, which offers a range of 94 quality products, including the iconic Mysuru Sandal soap, enjoys strong demand not only in North Karnataka but also in neighbouring States such as Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and Maharashtra.

Keeping this in view, a manufacturing unit will be set up on 50 acres in the Ittangihal industrial area of Vijayapura. This is expected to promote industrial growth, generate employment and expand market reach in the region, he said.

PROJECT COST

The total project cost of ₹227.91 crore includes ₹30 crore for land acquisition, ₹77.88 crore for construction, ₹24 crore for infrastructure and ₹70.80 crore for machinery. He added that several initiatives had been undertaken over the past three years, including branding, promotion, marketing, quality management, exports and e-commerce.

Karnataka allots 140 acres to Applied Materials of US

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The Karnataka Cabinet has approved the allocation of 140 acres at Bengaluru Signature Business Park (BSBP), located near Kempegowda airport, for ₹780 crore to US-based semiconductor equipment major Applied Materials Inc.

The Cabinet suggested that the cost be pegged at ₹780 crore with the consideration of the land at ₹1,288 per sq ft.

The business park is emerging as a key destination for high-tech industries and occupies over 400 acres.

Law and Parliamentary Affairs Minister HK Patil said the allocation was done on a lease-cum-sale basis subject to regulatory clearances and final pricing mechanisms after examining valuation norms aligned with guideline value.

> **The State Cabinet has suggested that the land cost** be pegged at ₹780 crore at ₹1,288 per sq ft

The government will review mechanisms for the disposal of the 267 acres of land remaining through diverse modes, which also includes competitive bidding and transaction advisers.

It is also set to re-examine BSBP's land disposal policy. This decision is in line with the State's aggressive push to its semiconductor and advanced technology strategy.

TO ADVERTISE PLEASE CONTACT
Bengaluru : 080-22071826
Mangaluru : 0824-2417575
Hubballi : 0836-2335700
thehindu businessline.

BENGALURU
businessline.
SATURDAY - MAY 2 - 2026

QUICKLY.

US confirms deal with seven AI companies

Washington: The Pentagon said on Friday that it had reached agreements with seven AI companies to deploy their capabilities on the Defense Department's classified networks. SpaceX, OpenAI, Google, NVIDIA, Reflection, Microsoft and Amazon Web Services will be integrated into the Pentagon's Impact Levels 6 and 7 network environments to "streamline data synthesis, elevate situational understanding, and augment war fighter decision-making in complex operational environments," the statement said. REUTERS

CuraTeQ gets Health Canada nod for biosimilar

New Delhi: Aurobindo Pharma on Friday said its arm CuraTeQ Biologics has received a compliance notice from Health Canada's Biologics and Radiopharmaceutical Drugs Directorate for its bevacizumab biosimilar Bevqolva, indicated in the treatment of different types of cancer. PTI

US Treasury warns ships not to pay Hormuz tolls

Washington: Any shipper paying tolls to Iran for passage through the Strait of Hormuz, including charitable donations to organisations such as the Iranian Red Crescent Society, is at risk of punitive sanctions, the US Treasury warned on Friday. Tehran has proposed fees or tolls on vessels passing through the Strait as part of proposals to end the war with Israel and the United States. The Treasury Office advised companies this week that paying the tolls puts them at risk, but clarified on Friday that payments disguised through charity or indirect payments are not allowed. REUTERS

Centre allows *force majeure* relief for govt contracts hit by West Asia war

PENALTY WAIVER. Govt permits extension of contractual timelines without penalties in affected cases

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The Centre has recognised the ongoing West Asia situation as a *force majeure* event, allowing extension of contractual timelines by two to four months without penalties in cases where supply chain disruptions have affected execution of government contracts.

According to an office memorandum issued by the Ministry of Finance's Department of Expenditure on April 29, procuring entities may invoke *force majeure* for contracts impacted directly or consequentially by disruptions linked to the prevailing West Asia situation.

Notably, the clarification follows representations made by all the major industry bodies to the Ministry of Finance regarding supply chain disruptions affecting the drone sector.

Per the memorandum, the ongoing West Asia situation should be treated as "war" for the purpose of invoking *force majeure* provisions under government procurement rules.

Consequently, contractual obligations due on or after February 28, 2026, may be extended for a period ranging between two and four months without imposition of penalties or additional costs.

INDUSTRY PUSHBACK. The clarification follows representations from major industry bodies to the Ministry of Finance regarding supply chain disruptions

CASE-BY-CASE BASIS

The extension period will be determined by procuring entities on a case-by-case basis after examining the admissibility of *force majeure* claims.

Besides, the memorandum stated that delays in delivery or completion arising from *force majeure* events should not attract liquidated damages or denial clauses where suppliers, contractors, consultants or service providers are not at fault.

However, invocation of *force majeure* will be considered valid only where parties to the contract were not already in default of their obligations as of February 27, 2026.

Further, the memorandum also clarified that relief would apply only to non-performance directly attributable to disruptions arising from the West Asia situation.

On their part, industry stakeholders said the clarification acknowledges challenges faced by sectors dealing with component shortages, logistics delays and export restrictions.

PERMIT INVOCATION

Drone Federation India's President Smit Shah said the government's decision to permit invocation of *force majeure* in light of the ongoing West Asia situation is a timely step for the drone and defence manufacturing ecosystem.

The industry, Shah said, had been dealing with component shortages, logistics delays and tighter export controls over recent months, affecting delivery timelines.

In addition, he said the move provided greater predictability for manufacturers while supporting efforts to build a resilient and self-reliant drone ecosystem.

Petro price hike likely by third week

No decision yet on quantum of increase

Our Bureau
New Delhi, May 3

The expected increase in petrol, diesel and cooking gas (liquefied petroleum gas) prices may take place by the third week of this month. The Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, Mr M.S. Srinivasan, told select media persons here on Wednesday that a final decision on price revision would be taken after consultations between the Petroleum and Finance Ministries.

The state-owned oil marketing companies (OMCs) are estimated to suffer under recoveries in the range of Rs 72,000-Rs 75,000 crore in the full year at currently prevailing international crude prices unless the domestic petroleum product prices are reviewed, Mr Srinivasan said.

As on date the OMCs are losing Rs 9.80 per litre on petrol, Rs 10.20 per litre on diesel, Rs 16.60 per litre on kerosene and Rs 125 per cylinder on cooking gas. The Petroleum Secretary, however, said no decision had been taken yet on the quantum of increase on these products.

Official sources said that a meeting between the Petroleum and the Finance Secretaries is likely in the next few days to prepare a basic paper on the issue for the consideration of the Petroleum Minister, Mr Murli Deora, and the Finance Minister, Mr P. Chidambaram, who are slated to meet sometime next week. A formal proposal is then likely to be taken to the Prime Minister, Dr Manmohan Singh. A decision on the recommendations of the Dr C. Rangarajan Committee on petroleum pricing is also expected by then.

REVISION LIKELY

Sources also indicated that a revision in the prices of LPG and SKO (kerosene) may also be required under the current circumstances. Though there has been a pressing need to raise prices of all the four products, the Government has not allowed any increase in fuel costs since September last year. The price freeze led to losses by Indian Oil Corporation, Hindustan Petroleum Corporation and Bharat Petroleum Corporation in the quarter ended December 31.

Mounting losses

OMCs losing Rs 9.80/litre on petrol, Rs 10.20/litre on diesel, Rs 16.60/litre on kerosene and Rs 125/cylinder on cooking gas.
Decision on the recommendations of the Dr C. Rangarajan Committee is also expected.

A screen grab of the report carried by *businessline* in its edition dated May 4, 2006

20 years on, politics still dictates petrol prices

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Two decades ago, *businessline* was reporting on the same structural tensions in India's fuel pricing that continue to surface today, as the government once again opts for a status quo on retail oil prices despite rising global crude.

The persistence of this pattern underscores a central contradiction: While petrol and diesel were formally deregulated by the NDA government in 2002 under Petroleum Minister Ram Naik, pricing freedom has remained constrained by political considerations.

POLITICAL OPTICS

Back then, as now, oil marketing companies (OMCs) found themselves absorbing the impact of global price swings when domestic prices were held steady.

The intent of deregulation was to eliminate precisely this burden, freeing companies to adjust prices in line with international markets and reducing the need for subsidies. Yet, in practice, electoral cycles, inflation concerns and political optics have repeatedly intervened, preventing full pass-through of costs to consumers.

The result is a system that operates in a grey zone. When crude prices rise sharply, OMCs act as shock absorbers, delaying increases and accumulating losses. When prices fall, tax adjustments often limit the benefit reaching consumers. This asymmetry distorts market signals and undermines the very rationale of deregulation.

What has evolved is the context, not the core issue. India's import dependence has deepened, and global energy markets have become more volatile. Still, the underlying dilemma remains unchanged: OMCs are neither fully market-driven nor entirely state-supported.

The continuity is telling. Twenty years on, despite policy shifts and changing global dynamics, India's fuel pricing regime remains shaped as much by political compulsions as by economic logic, leaving OMCs to grapple with the same challenges.

Noida airport to start ops from June 15

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The Noida International Airport (NIA), located in Jewar township of the Greater Noida area, will begin commercial flight operations from June 15.

The launch of services follows the inauguration of the airport by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and the receipt of approval for the Aerodrome Security Programme from the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security.

The airport operator on Friday said that the approval confirms that the airport's security framework, systems and operating procedures are in place in line with regulatory requirements ahead of the start of commercial services.

SCHEDULE SOON

As per NIA, the commencement of operations is expected to create a new aviation gateway for passengers, airlines and cargo operators in the National Capital Region and north India.

Notably, IndiGo will operate the first flight from the airport, marking the beginning of scheduled passenger services. This will be followed by operations from Akasa Air and Air India Express.

Further details regarding schedules, destinations and passenger services are expected to be announced subsequently.

MEETING NEEDS

The airport, developed to cater to growing air travel demand, features modern terminal infrastructure, operational systems and multimodal connectivity.

According to NIA, the airport has been designed to offer an efficient passenger journey while supporting airlines through cost-effective and reliable operations.

Besides, the start of commercial operations is expected to support regional connectivity and contribute to economic activity across the wider region. The airport, which carries the IATA code DXN, is intended to serve the greater Delhi region and western Uttar Pradesh.

PASSENGER CAPACITY

The project is being developed, constructed and operated by Yamuna International Airport Private Limited, a wholly-owned subsidiary of Zurich Airport International AG.

CONCESSION PERIOD

The concession period for the airport commenced on October 1, 2021, and will remain valid for 40 years.

In its first phase, the airport includes one runway and one passenger terminal with an annual handling capacity of 12 million passengers.

Under the aviation facility's masterplan, the airport is expected to be expanded over time to serve more than 70 million passengers annually.

Airlines penalising pilots for filing fatigue reports, says association

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Pilots are being discouraged and penalised for filing fatigue reports, the Airline Pilots' Association of India (ALPA) said on Friday.

The association has called for public disclosure and a review of fatigue report data filed with the civil aviation regulator. ALPA made this demand following the untimely deaths of two pilots this week.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) requires airlines to establish a fatigue report management system. Airlines have to submit fatigue reports filed by pilots on a quarterly basis.

Data obtained from DGCA by NGO Safety Matters Foundation on the subject revealed a disturbing trend. "Air India received 1,578 fatigue reports from its pilots in 2025 and rejected 860 of them — a 54.5 per cent rejection rate. IndiGo received 8,721 reports and rejected 8,449 — a 96.9 per cent rejection rate," Captain Amit Singh of Safety Matters Foundation said in his report on Friday.

TRANSPARENCY PUSH. The association has called for public disclosure and a review of fatigue report data filed with the civil aviation regulator DGCA

Air India Express accepted all 278 reports filed in 2025, it said. IndiGo declined to comment, and Air India did not respond to an email.

Singh said that whenever an airline receives a fatigue report, the standard line of analysis is 'Did the pilot fly in excess of the DGCA prescribed time limit'? Since the answer is invariably no, the report is closed, he said.

ALPA said the information indicates an alarmingly low rate of acceptance of fatigue reports by operators. "Such trends are inconsistent with the principles of a just safety culture and undermine fatigue risk management systems," Captain Sam Thomas, President of ALPA India, said in a letter to the DGCA.

TIME-BOUND ROADMAP

The association demanded a time-bound roadmap for full implementation of flight duty time rules. It said extensions granted to various airlines posed a safety risk and should be withdrawn.

"The continued occurrence of untimely pilot fatalities and adverse health outcomes, particularly following the introduction and operational misuse of consecutive night duties, warrants urgent attention. Recent aviation incidents further reinforce the need to ensure that flight crew are not merely compliant with limits but are genuinely well-rested and operationally fit," the association said.

Apple posts record March quarter and double-digit revenue growth in Q2

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Apple Inc announced a record March quarter and a strong double-digit revenue growth in India and other emerging markets in the second quarter of FY26, led by "extraordinary" customer enthusiasm for its flagship iPhones.

The company posted quarterly revenue of $111.2 billion, up 17 per cent year-on-year but down 22 per cent sequentially, owing to supply constraints.

iPhone revenue grew 22 per cent on-year basis to $57 billion, driven by the iPhone 17 products, with double digit growth in the majority of markets, including India, Japan and Southeast Asia, among others.

HUGE OPPORTUNITY

On the Indian market, Tim Cook, Apple CEO, said he was "over-the-moon excited" about the country. "It's the second-largest smartphone market in the world and the third-largest PC market. Despite doing extremely well there for quite some time, we still have a modest share. That really speaks to the opportunity that we have," said Cook.

iPhone 17e, the newest addition to the iPhone lineup, performed as the "most powerful, capable, and versatile iPhone family" created by the company.

The iPhone 17 series accounted for more than 60 per cent of shipments in the quarter, reflecting the brand's successful strategy of prioritising its newest flagship models, as per IDC data. The remaining volume was comprised primarily of previous-generation models as Apple focused its marketing and supply chain efforts on the current lineup.

"The results underscore the high aspirational value of the Apple brand in India. Even with a reduction in the aggressive discounting and affordability programmes seen in Q1'26 compared to previous quarters, Apple achieved strong double-digit value growth. This performance highlights a maturing consumer base that prioritises premium experiences and the latest innovations over older, discounted hardware," said Upasana Joshi, Senior Research Manager, IDC India.

Mac revenue was $8.4 billion for the March quarter, up 6 per cent from a year-ago, despite supply constraints driven by higher-than-expected levels of demand. According to IDC, Apple gained market share in the quarter.

FUTURE COMPETITION

With Apple projected to grow in market share through 2026 and 2027, Tarun Pathak, Research Director at Counterpoint, argued that growing AI-ready installed base is laying the ground for their multi-year services growth.

"Apple remains positive on memory supply but is more constrained on the availability of advanced node SoC. Smartphone OEMs are expected to increasingly transfer the BoM (Bill of Materials) rise to end consumers. This also means more Android flagships entering iPhone's territory," he said.

Trump likely to raise tariffs on EU autos to 25%

Reuters
Washington

US President Donald Trump on Friday said he would be increasing tariffs on cars and trucks from the European Union to 25 per cent, saying that the EU had not complied with its trade deal.

TRADE DEAL

"Based on the fact the European Union is not complying with our fully agreed to Trade Deal, next week I will be increasing Tariffs charged to the European Union for Cars and Trucks coming into the United States," he wrote on social media.

"It is fully understood and agreed that, if they produce Cars and Trucks in U.S.A. Plants, there will be NO TARIFF," Trump added.

'We're happy to give up some market share, but won't do businesses that are risky'

bl.interview

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

Star Health and Allied Insurance, a market leader in the country's retail health insurance space, is planning to increase annual premium by high single digit in this fiscal, says its Chief Financial Officer Nilesh Kambli. He says the insurer is looking to maintain its market share or improve it marginally in FY27.

Edited excerpts:

Star Health and Allied Insurance's combined ratio for both the last financial year and for the last quarter improved. What were the reasons?

There was a sharp improvement in the loss ratio. The loss ratio improved by around 200 basis points for the last financial year. If you remember, FY25 was not a good year for us, and it was mainly for two reasons.

First was group business — whatever we had written was highly loss making. So, during the last half of FY26, we had given up group businesses. So, in the group segment we saw roughly a 12 per cent improvement in the loss ratio. The proportion of that business is only 5 per cent. The balance loss ratio improvement came from retail business. If you remember, we had been mentioning about multiple things — growth in the new business, the price hikes that we have taken on last year on 65 per cent of the portfolio.

Moreover, we had brought up multiple things to improve the claims efficiency to improve customer experiences. Like home healthcare services, telemedicine services, preventive and wellness initiatives. Also, fraud, waste and abuse is something which is very rampant when it comes to retail business.

> We had brought up multiple things to improve the claims efficiency such as home healthcare services, telemedicine services, preventive and wellness initiatives
>
> **NILESH KAMBLI,**
> Chief Financial Officer,
> Star Health and Allied Insurance

We had done a lot of things to improve that area as well. So, claims efficiency also gave us good benefits. And the last and the least is the underwriting. Also, we have been focusing on quality business. We are happy to give up some market share, but not do businesses which are risky, and where the inflation is higher, incidence of fraud is very high. The portability business is one segment which we have avoided. So, all these things have led to an improvement in the loss ratio.

In the current financial year, what is the combined ratio that you are looking at?

What we have stated is in FY28 we will have a mid teen to high teen return on equity (RoE). We are not giving any quarterly or yearly guidance. We had given long-term guidance of increase in the topline as well as bottomline, and that is what we are focusing on.

We are mainly focused on RoE targets because expense ratio and claims ratio depend upon various regulations and various market conditions. So, we don't want to comment on any individual things, but the combined ratio should continue to improve is what I can mention. We continue to grow our new business. Especially after the GST exemption, we have seen good growth in the new business. We believe, not at the same level, but the momentum should continue, and we should continue to grow our new business, especially in tier three cities where we have a very strong business and the under penetration is there when it comes to health insurance.

What kind of annual insurance premium increase is the company planning for this fiscal?

We will take price increases on an annual basis. So, for the current year also we have planned for certain price increases. Roughly 80 per cent of the portfolio will undergo price increase for FY27. It will help us beat inflation. In the last financial year, the average price increase on portfolio was eight to nine per cent — high single digit. We would take a similar price increase in the current year.

In the retail health segment, Star Health and Allied Insurance's market share is the highest in the country. What are the company's plans to increase the market share further in FY27?

Currently, we have 31.4 per cent market share in retail health.

It was around 31 per cent for the last three-four years now. In spite of the competition, we do only profitable business. We don't do businesses in loss making areas, we are still making that market share.

So, it is by design, we are happy to let go around 60-70 basis per market share. But as long as we are profitable, we are fine with it. We expect the market to grow 15-18 per cent range going forward, and we are growing at a similar range. So, we should maintain the market share, or may be marginally improve it.